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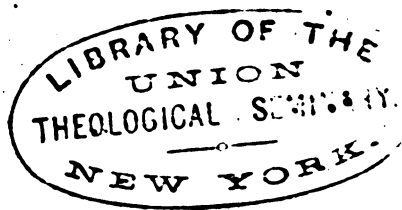


THE HISTORY
OF
CHRISTIANITY IN INDIA
FROM THE COMMENCEMENT OF THE
CHRISTIAN ERA.

BY THE
REV. JAMES HOUGH, M.A., F.C.P.S.

PERPETUAL CURATE OF HAM:
LATE CHAPLAIN TO THE HONOURABLE EAST-INDIA COMPANY AT MADRAS.

W. O. 41736
VOL. I.



PUBLISHED BY R. B. SEELEY AND W. BURNSIDE:
AND SOLD BY L. AND G. SEELEY,
FLEET STREET, LONDON.
MDCCCXXXIX.

1839

PRINTED BY L. AND G. SEELEY, THAMES DITTON, SURREY.

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TO
THE RIGHT REVEREND
CHARLES RICHARD,
• LORD BISHOP OF WINCHESTER,
• PRELATE OF THE MOST NOBLE ORDER OF THE GARTER,
ETC. ETC. ETC.
THE LIBERAL PATRON
OF
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TO THE
•
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THIS ATTEMPT TO RECORD THE RISE AND PROGRESS
OF
CHRISTIANITY IN INDIA
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PREFACE.

A HISTORY of Christianity in India has long been desired by persons interested in the progress of the Gospel in the East. The only general work of the kind, is the *Histoire du Christianisme des Indes*, by La Croze : a work little known in England, and, though of great value, yet not full enough for a mere translation of it to supply the desideratum. For the earlier annals of the Indian Church, the materials are very scanty ; and they are mixed up with much that tends to obscure, rather than elucidate, the few fragments of history that are unquestionably authentic. But there is no lack of information on the subject during the last three centuries, for readers who have leisure to explore its ample resources ; which, however, is by no means the case with all who are interested in their contents. So numerous are the volumes, consisting chiefly of portions of history and missionary correspondence, that have been published ; they are written in such a variety of languages ; and some of the most important of them are become so scarce ; that they are inaccessi-

ble to the generality of readers: and even of the persons who are competent and have opportunity to examine this variety of records, only a small proportion have time for the task. There can be no question, therefore, as to the importance of a work of moderate size that shall combine the information scattered over so wide a surface.

In publishing the present History, I do not pretend to have supplied the desideratum; for a much more extensive work would be desirable, had I leisure for the performance, and the means of incurring the responsibility of its publication. Neither am I entitled to the credit of entering upon the present limited undertaking merely for the purpose of meeting the general wish for such a work. The duties and responsibilities of my situation are too great for me to have thought of engaging in so laborious a task, had I not been constrained by a conviction of duty to the Church of Christ. No other motive could have induced me to sit down to write history, or to persevere in it when begun; for it is not without much inconvenience and many scruples that I have devoted to these volumes the time that they have required.

If asked, what constituted this constraint, I answer, —The pertinacity of the romanists in continuing to misrepresent the state of their own and the protestants' foreign missions. Like M. P. Norbert, a Romish missionary in India, who tells us that he was compelled by the Jesuits' libels to publish many things in justification of himself and his brethren;* so have I

* *Memoires Historiques, &c. tom. III. p. 423, &c. Les Apologistes de la Société par leurs Libelles ont contraint le P. Norbert à se justifier par des Pièces qu'il auroit tenu cachées.*

been urged, on former occasions as well as the present, from a similar cause, to expose the fallacy of their statements. In 1824 I was called upon to answer the Abbé Dubois's *Letters on the State of Christianity in India*; and evidence was given in my Reply to reverse the picture he had drawn, that, I have reason to know, proved satisfactory to readers of candour, and disabused the minds of several persons who had been misled by the opposite statements. The only attempt I heard of to answer my work, was an angry letter by a Bishop at Pondicherry, published in the Madras papers, to which I replied on the spot: and as nothing more appeared for some time on the subject, I ventured to hope that no similar attempt would be made to mislead the public mind. In this expectation, however, I have been disappointed. About six years ago writers of the Romish Church resumed the charge, repeating the calumnies of former authors, especially the misrepresentations of the Abbé Dubois, whom they quoted as an unquestionable authority, without noticing the confutation of his assertions. This disingenuous conduct came to my notice in November, 1833, and I met it immediately with a letter to the *Editor of the Record*, repeating the substance of my Reply. But this produced little effect upon the opposite party, whose confidence was then gathering strength to publish whatever they chose: and their subsequent proceedings soon convinced me, that to maintain a controversy with men so utterly regardless of their opponents' answers, was a hopeless contention. They write chiefly for their own people, very few of whom venture to read what is written on the protestant view of the subject; and thus the repetition of falsehood confirms them in the belief of its

truth. The success of these statements even upon protestants is much more extensive than may be suspected. For some persons, not sufficiently informed on the matter, are carried away by the confidence with which these writers put forth their assertions; and though they may read a pamphlet on the other side of the question, yet it soon shares the fate of most pamphlets, which are frequently put out of sight, and dismissed from the mind. Accordingly, when they hear the calumnies that it answered repeated, they have forgotten the arguments and facts that at one time, perhaps, seemed to them satisfactory, and they begin to feel inclined to think that there must be some truth in that which had appeared to be false. It is by no means uncommon to find persons of intelligence on other subjects so ill-informed upon this, as to credit the statements of these authors for no other reason but because positively made. When remonstrated with upon the impropriety of allowing themselves to be carried away by falsehoods so easy of detection, you shall often hear them reply—Such confident assertions can hardly be without some foundation:—and herein is proved the sagacity of Voltaire, as well as his want of probity, in the advice that he is said to have given to a controversialist to go on repeating his falsehood, without noticing its confutation, assuring him that at last it would be believed.

Such were the circumstances that convinced me that no satisfactory result was to be looked for from a mere controversy with these antagonists, however conducted, or to whatever length protracted. A History of Christianity in India seemed to present the only hope of fortifying the public mind against their assaults; and this thought first suggested the undertaking to my mind.

Of the manner in which the task is executed, the public will judge: but, while very far from indifferent what judgment may be pronounced upon it, I will confess that my chief solicitude has been about facts. This was demanded, as well for the integrity of the history, as for the sake of the parties chiefly implicated in the transactions here recorded. Exposing as they do the infamous conduct of Romish Missionaries, it was specially necessary to ascertain the truth of every statement, and for this reason I have omitted some of doubtful authority. I am not aware of having stated one fact that did not appear to me unquestionable; and *I pledge myself to withdraw every thing that can be PROVED contrary to the truth*. But I do not promise to take notice of any assertions that have already been confuted. My sole object has been to put the public in possession of a History that shall enable them to understand the merits of the question raised by the romanists to the prejudice of the protestant cause: and the end I desire to promote is, the glory of the Lord—an end not to be accomplished without the most scrupulous adherence to truth. Under this conviction, I shall deem nothing that may seem to affect the *integrity* of the work too unimportant to claim the best attention I can command.

During the past six years the confidence of romanists in England has increased more than, perhaps, at any former period since the Reformation. Their chapels and seminaries have been multiplied, but it does not follow that their converts have kept pace with them; for it is their well-known policy first to provide the building, and then to exert themselves to fill it. While, therefore, there is enough in their activity to keep protestants on the watch against their encroachments, we

should take care not to allow ourselves to be deluded by these appearances into the belief, that their progress is equal to their pretensions. Glad would they be to make such an impression on the public mind ; for it would tend to paralyse the timid, and to confirm the lukewarm in their indifference. They are now preparing extensive means of aggression, and threatening great things : but, in reliance upon the God of truth, we tell them, " Let not him that girdeth on his harness boast himself as he that putteth it off." (1 Kings xx. 11.)

Besides these exertions, we are informed, by the Hon. & Rev. George Spencer, that he has proposed to the Romish Clergy abroad to unite in prayer for the conversion of England to the Roman Church, and that they, especially the Archbishop and Clergy of Paris, have entered with zeal into his proposal. Of this there could be nothing to complain, if they would confine themselves to prayer for the Divine blessing on their instructions. No doubt nothing more is to be apprehended from the reverend gentleman with whom the proposal originated : but he does not yet know his newly adopted fraternity, if he imagines that they will be guided by his pacific suggestions, as soon as they shall have attained power to use means more in accordance with the history, the character, and the pretensions of their Church. The record of their proceedings in India here presented to the public, may teach him, and England, what we have to expect, should they ever obtain the object of their prayers.

But is this probable ? What prayers are the Romish priests using for the purpose ? The reverend gentleman informs us, that he was greatly encouraged in his proceedings for England's conversion, on being as-

sured, by some French priests, that they had made a beginning *by offering mass* on the first Thursday that occurred after his proposal. Surely he must have forgotten, or never could have rightly understood, the Creed and Liturgy of the Church he has forsaken, if he expects such prayers to obtain the answer desired. When we consider the character of this Mass—its adoration of a consecrated wafer; its invocation of the Virgin and other Saints; we feel that we have nothing to fear from it for the Protestant institutions of our country. Though the whole body of the Romish clergy should unite in this service, we believe that such prayers can injure none but those who offer them. Should the Lord be pleased again to bring Great Britain under the yoke of Rome, it will be, not in answer to these prayers, but in punishment for her own sins.

In the letter of a Romish Bishop in India alluded to above, one principal cause of the writer's displeasure was, my use of the term *Papist*, instead of *Catholic*, in the Reply to the Abbé Dubois. Nothing was more foreign from my intention than to give offence by using an obnoxious term, and therefore, in the present History I have adopted the word *romanist*. The term *papist* occurs indeed, but it will be found generally, if not exclusively, in quotations from other authors. If asked, why I have not called them *Catholics*, since it is the name which they prefer, I answer—Because of the advantage that they disingenuously take of our use of the term. The Church of England retains the word *Catholic* in her Liturgy, and the romanists know that we do not use it in their exclusive sense, but apply it universally to all that have been baptized in the name of the Trinity, hold the true faith in Jesus Christ, have “the pure word

of God preached " to them, and the Sacraments " duly administered according to Christ's ordinance in all those things that of necessity are requisite to the same." (Article xix.) The Church of England regards all other churches who answer to this character as united with her to Jesus, their common Head, by communion of the same Spirit. Though varying in outward circumstances, and in matters not essential to salvation, they form various branches of the Catholic, or Universal Church. Yet romanists well know, that many members of both our Church and theirs do not make this distinction, but apply the term exclusively to that of Rome: and, taking advantage of this ignorance in some, and negligence in others, they charge us with inconsistency in using the term, while we protest against their Church. Whereas, they know that protestants use it in its legitimate sense; and the inconsistency is theirs, in applying it only to their own communion.

Are we then to be charged with illiberality for refusing to concede to them this name, while they persist in making so unfair a use of the concession? This is not a mere logomachy. Truly has it been said—"Names are things." For protestants to call romanists *Catholics*, is to put a weapon in their hands which they neglect no opportunity to wield against us. While in courtesy yielding the name, they pretend that we concede the principle it implies; and hereby we expose our brethren, who do not take trouble, or have not ability to discriminate, to the designs of these enemies to the truth and freedom of the Gospel. The single point they keep in view is, that theirs is the only Catholic Church; that all Christians out of her

pale, by whomsoever baptized, owe allegiance to the Pope; and that every term is to be repudiated that implies the existence of any Church independent of Rome. *Catholic* is the name that best accords with these arrogant pretensions; no wonder, therefore, that they so strenuously contend for it: but for the same reason should protestants resist their exclusive appropriation of it to their own communion. *Papist* is, undoubtedly, their most appropriate designation, for it implies an acknowledgment of the Papal supremacy and infallibility, which they alone believe; and the learned Bossuet, and others of their best writers were not ashamed to use it. In the days of those authors, indeed, it was not in such bad odour as it is at present, and this is the real cause of the modern romanists anxiety to get rid of it: but unless their character is altered, they will gain nothing by changing their name. There are countries where even the word *Catholic* is as odious* as the term *Papist* ever was in Europe: and wherever the light and liberty of the Gospel shall predominate, no mere appellation will shield the darkness and tyranny of Rome from general abhorrence. Should the account of the Roman Church in India given in the following pages, tend to awaken the public mind to the danger of her present encroachments, I shall be grateful to God for the result, and deem myself amply recompensed for all my pains.

The Synod of Diamper is the leading event of the Romish Missions in Malabar, and it develops the character of their entire history. There could be no ques-

* See Smith and Dwight's *Missionary Researches in Armenia*. p. 392, &c.

tion, therefore, as to the necessity of giving in detail the account of its proceedings, together with the circumstances that preceded and followed it. At the same time, the length of its Decrees created some difficulty. As they contain the only authentic account extant of the doctrines and practice of the Syrian Church in Malabar, previous to this atrocious Synod, I could not consent to curtail them. Yet, if given in the body of the work, they would nearly have filled a volume of the ordinary size ; and an analysis of them is, no doubt, sufficient for the general reader of history. Such an analysis is given by La Croze, for which he has incurred the censure of some Romish writers. It seemed, therefore, essential to the character of the work, as well as due to myself, to publish them entire ; and while consulting the reader's convenience by giving a brief abstract of them in the text, the whole are printed in smaller type in the Appendix. Persons who have neither leisure nor curiosity to consult such records, may deem this unnecessary ; but I shall be disappointed if the student of ecclesiastical history does not consider them a valuable appendage to the work.

During the progress of these volumes, a paragraph appeared in the public papers, stating that the Bishop of Calcutta was composing a similar history, for which he was said to have collected some valuable materials during his recent visit to the Syrian Church in Malabar. I applied immediately to the Bishop's son, the Vicar of Islington, to ascertain the fact, and was assured by that gentleman that he believed the report to be without foundation. I then wrote to the Bishop himself, and as his Lordship's answer, while it confirms his son's opinion, also shows the importance that he

attaches to such a work, I venture to transcribe that part of it which relates to the subject.

"I wish I were writing, my dear friend, **THE HISTORY OF CHRISTIANITY IN INDIA**. It is a glorious theme to those who have health, materials, leisure—of none of which three have I the least portion. How the report got into the papers, I cannot for a moment conjecture, unless it were, that, upon hearing of my 20,000 miles of travel, some one had confounded the opportunity, with the health, materials, and leisure of such an undertaking. It never entered my thoughts." Then, in answer to my request for such information as he might have to communicate, his Lordship states, that he has not collected any; assures me, that "the rumoured collections of the Syrian Churches are all a dream;" and refers me to several sources of information from which I had previously drawn. In conclusion, he earnestly persuades me to "to pursue the work with vigour," and encourages me to persevere: and I cannot refrain from acknowledging thus publicly the kindness of his proposal carefully to revise a few sheets of the work, though it is too late to avail myself of the advantage it would have derived from such a revision. Considering his Lordship's incessant avocations, this was a favour I did not venture to ask; but I should certainly have been induced to wait for it, had I contemplated the probability of his finding time to give any attention to the manuscript.

In the prosecution of the undertaking, I have spared no pains to obtain access to all the authentic documents extant; and as their titles, together with, in some cases, a description of their authors and their contents, are given when first quoted, it is unnecessary to enu-

merate them here. I am not aware of having made use of one work of doubtful authority ; and the facts that were likely to be questioned by romanists if not well authenticated, I have been specially careful to establish by reference to authors of their own communion. It has been a weary task to wade through such a mass of legendary tales, and to find so little of the light of truth to relieve the toil of the investigation. Volume after volume of ecclesiastical matter have I read, jaded and disappointed to discover nothing like Christianity to extract ; and more than once I have doubted whether it were right to retain the present title of the work, so little does it answer to the general character of the Syrian Church and the Romish Missions in India. With this feeling I quite respond to the sentiment of a friend who has taken the trouble to read the entire manuscript. In returning the papers, he writes—"They are painfully interesting—but can you get no scrap of history that discovers divine faith or Christian graces in the poor Syrian Churches? They had the Scriptures among them, and surely they were not like dead corpses all through their history. Does Fabricius give nothing in his *Lux Evangelii*? It is greatly to be regretted that the interior and spiritual history is absent and lost. Where is the faith, hope and love of the Gospel? Where is the *Blessed with all spiritual blessings in heavenly things in Christ*? You cannot *make* what the remnants of history do not give you ; but no doubt there could not have been such a conflict with Rome, and such a victory, without some internal principles of real and evangelical truth at the bottom. The great spiritual lessons of the history are left in obscurity for want of insight into their actual spiritual

state, and this will only fully be given hereafter in the day of the Lord."

Though not in my power to supply the great deficiency here so affectingly deplored, yet I have occasionally given expression to the feelings that afforded relief to my own mind, and have now only to desire that they may produce a similar effect upon that of the reader. If they do not show all that I desire to exhibit of the true Spirit of Christ and His people, together with their heavenly life, yet the contrast it is attempted to present may enable readers, in some measure, to see the partial character of the History in its present development, and induce them to wait with patient devotion, a future discovery of its meaning and intent. In God's own time and way, He will bring hidden things to light; and, therefore, will we always patiently abide His pleasure, and praise Him more and more.

The two volumes now published will be found to include the History of the Syrian Church and the Romish Missions to the commencement of the present century. The remaining two volumes will give the history of the Protestant Missions. Some progress is made in them, but it was deemed advisable, in the mean time, to give this first Section to the public: and while I regret that it contains so little to satisfy the mind that is chiefly interested in the progress of Divine Truth, I can venture to promise that the latter Section will correspond better to the title of the work.

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A HISTORY

OF

CHRISTIANITY IN INDIA.

BOOK I.

CHAPTER I.

**A BRIEF DISSERTATION ON THE OPENING OF THE
INTERCOURSE BETWEEN THE WESTERN NA-
TIONS AND THE EAST INDIES.**

OF all histories, the history of the kingdom of God in the world is the most important. Christianity is the commencement of that kingdom in its spiritual character, and the account of its progress will interest the mind according to our estimate of its worth. If we regard the achievements of men as of superior moment to the conquests of truth, we shall feel more concern in the rise and fall of temporal dominions, than in the advancement of Christ's religion upon earth: but, if duly penetrated with the consequences of the fall, and with gratitude to God for the means which He has provided to remedy those

*Preliminary
remarks.*

CHAP.
I.

evils, no record of human conquests, whatever civil benefits they may secure, will be read with half the interest we shall take in the progress of a religion that brings "Glory to God in the highest, and on earth peace, good will toward men."¹

This feeling will gather strength, as we turn our thoughts from the universal church, to any section of it in which we are more immediately concerned. The interest felt in the general diffusion of the Gospel cannot fail to be increased when our attention is directed to its successes in our own country : and since Eastern India now forms so considerable a portion of the British empire, the history of Christianity in that extensive region, ought to be read with somewhat of the augmented interest that we take in the evangelizing of the land that gave us birth.

To further the cause of Christianity is a sacred duty incumbent upon all who have avouched Jesus Christ to be their Lord ; for His last command to His disciples, to go "into all the world, and preach the gospel to every creature," claims their attention in all ages and in every land, to the extent of their capabilities. How vast then the responsibility of Great Britain, to whom the Almighty has intrusted the empire of India ! But we are too much accustomed to lose sight of our individual duty in the general obligation of the state. Every Christian is responsible to God for whatever means and opportunity he may possess, to make known the tidings of salvation among men : and while a nation, in its collective character, can suffer only in the present world for the neglect of its responsibilities, each

¹ Luke ii. 14.

individual will be judged in the next. Instead then of overlooking our own obligations, in the contemplation of those that belong to our country, they ought rather to be kept the more vividly in view. Sitting down to the present history with the mind thus disposed for instruction, we may, with the Divine blessing, derive improvement from what we read, and be stimulated thereby to enter upon the work to which it will invite us with an energy commensurate to its importance.

1. The Saviour's command first claims our attention. "Jesus came and spake unto the disciples, saying, All power is given unto me in heaven and in earth. Go ye therefore, and teach all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Ghost: teaching them to observe all things whatsoever I have commanded you: and, lo, I am with you alway, even unto the end of the world."¹ These were His last words to those whom He had chosen to lay the foundation of His kingdom in the world. They did not enter immediately upon their commission, but, in obedience to their Lord's directions, awaited the descent of the Holy Ghost, which He had led them to expect, saying, "Behold, I send the promise of my Father upon you: but tarry ye in the city of Jerusalem, until ye be endued with power from on high."² Accordingly, when "He was parted from them, and carried up into heaven," "they worshipped Him, and returned to Jerusalem with great joy: and were continually in the temple, praising and blessing God."

The
Saviour's
command
to His
apostles.

¹ Matt. xxviii. 18—20.

² Luke xxiv. 49, 51—53.

CHAP.
I.

Holy Ghost
descends
upon them.

2. "And when the day of Pentecost was fully come, they were all with one accord in one place. And suddenly there came a sound from heaven as of a rushing mighty wind, and it filled all the house where they were sitting. And there appeared unto them cloven tongues like as of fire, and it sat upon each of them. And they were all filled with the Holy Ghost, and began to speak with other tongues, as the Spirit gave them utterance."¹ Endued thus miraculously with grace and ability for the work, "they went forth, and preached every where, the Lord working with them, and confirming the word with signs following."² With such diligence did the first preachers of Christianity attend to their Lord's instructions, that within thirty years from the descent of the Holy Ghost upon them, St Paul applied to their unparalleled exertions to instruct mankind in the Gospel, the very terms in which David described the revolution of the heavenly bodies. — "Their sound went into all the earth, and their words unto the ends of the world."³ It is not probable that the apostle meant these expressions to be understood literally of all the countries then known to the civilized world. They are to be taken metaphorically, as descriptive of the vast extent to which the glad tidings of salvation had already been conveyed.

Uncertain
whether India
was visited by an
apostle.

3. Whether India was honoured with the presence of an inspired apostle, is a question involved in great uncertainty. Of its probability, or otherwise, we may perhaps be able to judge, from a brief review of the events which led to the opening of that continent to the natives of the West. Geography is truly said

¹ Acts ii. 1—4.

² Mark xvi. 20.

³ Rom. x. 18.

to have been chiefly indebted for its improvement to the wars and commerce of nations ; and the all-wise Ruler of the world has made the same means subsidiary to the diffusion of Divine truth. Mankind, intent on the objects of their ambition, are as unconscious as the winds that blow, of the subserviency of their exertions to the Almighty's designs. Even the hearts of kings are in His rule and governance, and He disposes and turns them as it seemeth best to His godly wisdom.¹ And as of monarchs, so of their subjects, all their projects and exertions are under the absolute control of the King of Kings. When He causes them to prosper in the world, they have their reward ; but it is earthly, and fadeth away suddenly like the grass. The permanent fruit of their endeavours is reaped by the church of God, and the glory that may result from them must ultimately return to Him.

4. With this recognition of a wise and gracious Providence guiding all human affairs to accomplish His own designs, we regard Alexander the Great, King of Macedon, as an important agent raised up by the Almighty, to prepare a way for the Gospel in the East. For that ambitious prince first opened India to the people of the West, and the opening that he effected was never again entirely closed. The country, indeed, had long been partially known to the natives of Egypt and Syria, by means of the commerce carried on between those countries. The most ancient navigators of whom we read, are the Egyptians and Phenicians, whose first voyages were made in the Mediterranean, called in sacred writ, the Great Sea, and the Sea of

India first
known to
the Egyptians
and
Phenicians.

¹ Prov. xxi. 1. Eng. Liturgy. Com. Service.

CHAP.
I.

Egyptians
relinquish
maritime
pursuits.

Tarshish. Their trade, however, was not long confined to the countries bordering on its shores. Acquiring early possession of some ports on the Arabian Gulf, they extended the sphere of their commerce, and are represented as the first people of the West who opened a communication with India by sea.¹

5. The Indian trade was soon engrossed by the Phenicians, who for many ages continued in undisturbed possession of the monopoly, the Egyptians becoming indifferent about the commerce, while they could obtain the commodities of the East without personal risk or trouble. The fertile soil and temperate climate of Egypt producing the necessaries and comforts of life in rich profusion, rendered the inhabitants almost independent of other countries; and they laid aside their maritime pursuits for so long a season, that they began at last to think themselves the greatest nation in the world; and it became an established maxim of their policy, to renounce all intercourse with foreigners. In consequence of this, they held other people, as well as the Hebrews,² in abomination; and they especially regarded all sea-faring persons as impious and profane. In the end they carried this prejudice so far, that they actually fortified their harbours, and refused admission to strangers.

B. C.
1491.
Sesostris
revives
them. He
marches
across India.

6. The enterprising ambition of Sesostris, king of Egypt, disdaining the restraints imposed upon it by these contracted ideas of his subjects, prompted him to render the Egyptians a commercial people; and in the course of his reign he so completely accomplished this, that, if we

¹ Robertson's Historical Disquisition concerning antient India, p. 5.

² Gen. xliii. 32; xlv. 34.

B.C.
1491.

may give credit to some historians, he was able to fit out a fleet of four hundred ships in the Arabian Gulf, which conquered all the countries stretching along the Egyptian sea to India. At the same time, his army, led by himself, marched through Asia, and subjected to his dominion every part of it, as far as the banks of the Ganges: whence, crossing that river, he advanced to the Eastern Ocean. Some are of opinion that these efforts produced no permanent effect:¹ but others have very reasonably conjectured, that they wrought a considerable change in the manners of the inhabitants, and that several laws and customs now prevailing in India, which resemble those of ancient Egypt, were introduced by Sesostris at the time of his invasion.² His subjects, however, were too proud, or too indolent, to derive any immediate benefit from his exertions. They appear to have been so contrary to the genius and habits of the Egyptians, that, on the death of Sesostris, they resumed their ancient maxims, and many ages elapsed before the commercial connexion of Egypt with India came to be of much importance.³

7. The Egyptians willingly abandoned the toils and the gains of commerce generally, as well as those of India, to the more enterprising inhabitants of Phenicia, the situation of whose country was favourable to the commercial spirit. The territory which they possessed was neither large nor fertile. It was from trading with

Phenicians permitted to hold the monopoly of the Indian trade;— theirs the earliest route of communication with India.

¹ Robertson's India.

² La Croze. *Histoire du Christianisme des Indes*, p. 434. This subject will be noticed more particularly in the account to be given of the Mythology and Customs of India.

³ Herodotus, Diodorus Siculus. See Rollin, vol. i. pp. 78—83.

CHAP.

I.

other countries only that they could derive either opulence or power. Accordingly, the traffic carried on by the Phenicians of Sidon and Tyre, was extensive and adventurous; and, both in manners and policy, they resembled the great commercial states of modern times, more than any people in the ancient world. Among the various branches of their commerce, that with India may be regarded as one of the most considerable and lucrative. As by their situation on the Mediterranean, and the imperfect state of navigation, they could not attempt to open a direct communication with India by sea; the adventurous spirit of ambition prompted them to wrest from the Idumeans some commodious harbours towards the bottom of the Arabian Gulf. From these they had a regular intercourse with India on the one hand, and with the eastern and southern coasts of Africa on the other. The distance, however, from the Arabian Gulf to Tyre, was considerable, and rendered the conveyance of goods thither by land carriage so tedious and expensive, that it became necessary for them to take possession of Rhinocolura, the nearest port in the Mediterranean to the Arabian Gulf. Thither all the commodities brought from India were conveyed over land by a route much shorter, and more practicable, than that by which the productions of the East were, at a subsequent period, carried from the opposite shore of the Arabian Gulf to the Nile. At Rhinocolura they were shipped again, to be transported by an easy navigation to Tyre, and thence distributed through the world. This is the earliest route of communication with India of which we have any authentic description; and it had so many advantages over any other ever known before the

modern discovery of a new course of navigation to the East, that the Phenicians could supply other nations with the productions of India in greater abundance, and at a cheaper rate, than any people of antiquity. This circumstance, for a considerable time, secured to them a monopoly of that trade; and so extraordinary was the wealth of individuals, that it rendered the "merchants of Tyre, princes, and her traffickers the honourable of the earth:"¹ while the power of the state itself became so extensive, that it first taught mankind to conceive what vast resources a commercial people possess, and what great exertions they are capable of making.²

B. C.
992

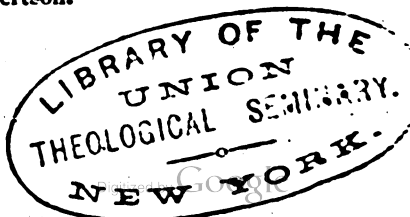
8. The Jews, by their vicinity to Tyre, had a favourable opportunity to observe the wealth which flowed into that city, from the lucrative commerce carried on by the Phenicians, and they were induced to aim at obtaining a share of it. This they effected under the prosperous reigns of David and Solomon, partly by the conquests which they made of a small district in the land of Edom, whereby they obtained possession of the harbours of Elath and Esiongeber on the Red Sea. They were assisted also by the friendship of Hiram, king of Tyre, who enabled Solomon to fit out fleets, which, under the direction of Phenician pilots, sailed to Tarshish and Ophir.³ In what region of the earth we should search for these famous ports, which furnished the navy of Solomon with the various commodities enumerated by the sacred historians, is an inquiry that has long exercised the industry of learned men. Ophir was early

B. C.
992.
The Jews' attention drawn to this commerce.

¹ Isaiah xxiii. 8.

² Robertson.

³ 1 Kings ix. 26; x. 22.



CHAP.
I.

supposed to be situated in some part of India, and the Jews were thought to be one of the nations which traded with that country. But the opinion now more generally adopted is, that Solomon's fleets, after passing the straits of Babelmandel, held their course along the south-west coast of Africa, as far as the kingdom of Sofala, a country so celebrated for its rich mines of gold and silver, that it has been denominated by Oriental writers—the Golden Sofala. It abounded also in all the other articles which composed the cargoes of Solomon's ships.¹ The Jews, then, we may conclude, have no title to be reckoned among the nations which carried on intercourse with India by sea.

B. C.
510.

Persians obtain the first foreign establishment in India.

9. The first establishment of any foreign power in India, which can be ascertained by evidence meriting any degree of credit, is that of the Persians; and even of this we have only a very general and dubious account. Darius, the son of Hystaspes, king of Persia, possessed an active and enterprising spirit. Having subjected to his dominion many of the countries which stretched south-east from the Caspian Sea towards the river Oxus, his curiosity was excited to acquire a more extensive and accurate knowledge of India, on which they bordered. But his conquests do not seem to have extended beyond the district watered by the Indus, nor was any general knowledge of India diffused at that time in consequence of his expedition.

B. C.
326.

Alexander the Great covets the Indian com-

10. About one hundred and sixty years after the reign of Darius Hystaspes, Alexander the Great undertook his celebrated expedition into India. Soon after his first successes in Asia, he

¹ Calmet's Dictionary on Tarshish and Ophir.

B. C.
326.

merce—he
founds Alex-
andria to fa-
cilitate the
communica-
tion.

seems to have formed the idea of establishing a universal monarchy, and to have aspired to the dominion of the sea as well as of the land. From the wonderful efforts of the Tyrians in their own defence, when left without any ally or protector, he conceived a high opinion of the resources of maritime power, and of the wealth to be derived from commerce, especially that with India, which he found engrossed by the citizens of Tyre. With a view to secure this commerce, and to establish a station for it that should be preferable in many respects to that of Tyre, as soon as he had completed the conquest of Egypt, he founded a city near one of the mouths of the Nile, which he honoured with his own name. With such admirable discernment was the situation chosen, that ALEXANDRIA soon became the greatest trading city in the ancient world; and, notwithstanding many successive revolutions in empire, it continued during eighteen centuries to be the chief seat of commerce with India. Amidst the military operations to which Alexander was soon obliged to turn his attention, the desire of acquiring the lucrative trade which the Tyrians had carried on with the East, was never relinquished. Events soon occurred, that not only confirmed and added strength to this desire, but also opened to him a prospect of obtaining the sovereignty of those regions which supplied the rest of mankind with so many precious commodities.

11. After his final victory over the Persians, in his pursuit of the last Darius, and of Bessus, the murderer of that unfortunate monarch, he was led to traverse that part of Asia which stretches from the Caspian Sea beyond the river Oxus. He advanced towards the East as

Commences
his first ex-
pedition to
India.

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New York

CHAP.
1.

far as Maracanda, then a city of some importance, and destined in a future period, under the modern name of Samarcand, to be the capital of an empire not inferior to his own either in extent or power. In a progress of several months, through provinces hitherto unknown to the Greeks; in a line of march often approaching near to India, and among people accustomed to much intercourse with its inhabitants; he learned many things concerning the state of a country that had been long the object of his thoughts and ambition, which increased his determination to invade it. Decisive in all his resolutions, and prompt in their execution, he soon set out from Bactria, and crossed that ridge of mountains which, under various denominations, forms what oriental geographers have called the Stony Girdle. This range of gigantic hills environs Asia, and constitutes the northern barrier of India.

Is compelled
to return.

12. After passing the Indus, Alexander marched forward in the road that leads directly to the Ganges and the opulent provinces to the south-east, now comprehended under the general name of Hindoostan. But on the banks of the Hydaspes, known in modern times by the name of the Jhylum, he was opposed by Porus, a powerful monarch of the country, at the head of a numerous army, whom he overcame, and received the submission of Porus himself and his allies. This and other interruptions that he met with, induced him to alter his route. Stimulated by the descriptions he had received of the Ganges, he continued to press onward towards that mighty river and the regions through which it flows: but on reaching the banks of the Hyphasis, the modern Beyah, in the Punjab of Lahore, his army with one voice refused to

advance further. They had already done so much, and suffered so severely, chiefly from excessive rains and extensive inundations, that their patience and strength were exhausted : and they persisted with such sullen obstinacy in their determination to return, that even Alexander, though possessed in the highest degree of every quality that gains ascendancy over the minds of military men, was obliged to yield, and to issue orders for marching back to Persia.

13. Before setting out from the Hydaspes for the East, Alexander left some officers behind, with orders to build and collect as many vessels as possible during his absence : and on his return to that river, he found that they had executed his instructions with so much diligence, that a numerous fleet was waiting his arrival. Amidst the hurry of war and the rage of conquest, he never lost sight of his pacific and commercial schemes. The destination of his fleet was to sail down the Indus to the Ocean, then to proceed from the mouth of that river to the Persian Gulf, that a communication by sea might thus be opened with India and the centre of his dominions. The distance between the ocean and the place on the Hydaspes where this fleet was fitted out, cannot be less than one thousand British miles. Soon after they reached the mouth of the Indus, Alexander, satisfied with having accomplished this arduous undertaking, led his army by land back to Persia. The command of the fleet, with a considerable body of troops on board, he left to Nearchus, who, after a coasting voyage of seven months, conducted it safely up the Persian Gulf into the Euphrates.

Opens a communication by sea with India and his dominions.

14. In this manner did Alexander first open the knowledge of India to the people of Europe,

Customs and manners of India at that

CHAP.

L

period con-
tinue unal-
tered.

Extent of
Alexander's
projects.

His death.

and an extensive district of that vast country was surveyed with greater accuracy than could have been expected from the short time that he remained there. From the accounts of the campaign written by three of his principal officers¹ we learn, that at that early period India was divided into regular monarchies of considerable extent. They describe with accuracy the climate, soil, and productions of the country. Their descriptions of the inhabitants, with their manners, customs, and even dress, correspond minutely with what we now observe, though at the distance of more than two thousand years.

15. When Alexander invaded India, he had something more in view than a transient campaign. It was his object to annex that extensive and opulent region to his empire; and though the refractory spirit of his army compelled him, at that time, to suspend the prosecution of his design, he was far from relinquishing it. Having established a medium of communication with the interior of Hindoostan, he proposed to convey the valuable commodities of that country down the Indus, then to transmit them from the Persian Gulf into the interior parts of his Asiatic dominions; while by the Arabian Gulf they were to be carried to Alexandria, and thence distributed to the rest of the world.

16. Grand and extensive as these schemes were, the precautions taken against disappointment, and the arrangements made for carrying them into effect, were so various, and so judicious, that Alexander had reason to entertain sanguine hopes of their proving successful. But his race was run. A premature death put

¹ Ptolemy, the son of Lagus, Aristobulus, and Nearchus.

an end to all his ambitious calculations. He had fulfilled the purpose for which Divine Providence had raised him up;¹ and in little more than a year after his expedition to India, this mighty conqueror was carried off in a fit of intemperance. How humiliating a spectacle of human greatness destroyed by human weakness! No hand can lay a mortal so prostrate as his own. He for whose ambition the world was too small, could not conquer his vicious propensities, and they mastered him at the zenith of his glory. "Lord, what is man?" A compound of inconsistencies. The good in him that mercy has permitted to survive the fall, cannot preserve him from the evil that he inherits; and, but for Divine grace preventing, his passions will predominate over the best feelings of his heart, and lay his honour in the dust.

17. Not long after Alexander's death, his vast empire was divided between his four principal officers, but not without many severe contests in the partition. Macedon and Greece were given to Cassander: Thrace, with several provinces of lower Asia, fell to the share of Lysimachus: Egypt was the portion of Ptolemy, afterwards surnamed Soter: and upper Asia became the dominion of Seleucus. Accordingly it devolved on the latter two, Ptolemy and Seleucus, to carry into effect Alexander's intention regarding the commerce with India; and they both showed themselves willing and com-

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323.
Division of
his empire
between
four of his
officers.

¹ The devout reader of the Bible, and the attentive observer of the ways of God with men, will not hesitate to subscribe to this sentiment. The removal of Alexander, and the immediate division of his empire, were in exact accordance with the prophecies of these events delivered more than two hundred years before they occurred. (Dan. vii. 6; viii. 8.)

CHAP.
I.

Seleucus, king of Syria, pursues Alexander's scheme of conquest in India, which is ultimately abandoned by his successors.

petent to prosecute the undertaking which he had so ably planned and commenced.

18. Seleucus, king of Syria, possessed much of the ambitious spirit of his master, as well as the eastern division of his conquests. He, like all the officers formed under Alexander, entertained such high notions of the advantages to be derived from a commercial intercourse with India, as induced him to march into that country to secure them. We have no particular account of his expedition. All we know is, that his pretext for undertaking it was some hostile demonstrations, real or imagined, on the part of Sandracottus, king of the Prasii;¹ against whom he carried on a successful war, advancing considerably beyond the utmost boundary of Alexander's progress eastward. Compelled to return for the defence of his dominions against Antigonus, he concluded a treaty of peace with Sandracottus, and sent a confidential officer, Megasthenes, to cultivate a friendly intercourse with that prince. The Prasii over whom he reigned were a powerful nation on the banks of the Ganges. Megasthenes executed his commission with fidelity, resided in the capital of the Prasii many years, and was probably the first European who beheld the river Ganges. The position of Palibothra is, with great probability, supposed to be the same with that of the modern city of Allahabad, at the confluence of the two great rivers, Jumna and Ganges. Alexander did not advance further than the spot where the modern city of Lahore is situated.

¹ 'The Prasii were the descendants of Pooru of Poorag, visited by Megasthenes, ambassador of Seleucus, and the principal city of the Yadus, ere it sent forth the four branches from Satwati.'—Annals and Antiquities of Rajast'han, by Lt. Col. JAMES TOD, Vol. I., p. 39.

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Megasthenes, who was an officer in his army, became thoroughly acquainted with all that was hitherto known of India : he was, therefore, well qualified to describe, for the information of his countrymen, the nature and importance of the regions he had traversed. Though he was too fond of the marvellous, yet his accounts are considered, on the whole, worthy of credit. From his writings the ancients seem to have derived almost all their knowledge of the interior of India ; and from comparing the three most ample accounts of those regions extant, by Diodorus Siculus, Strabo, and Arrian, they appear manifestly, from their near resemblance, to be a transcript of the words of Megasthenes.

His embassy to Sandracottus, and another of Daimachus to his son and successor, Allitrochidas, are the last transactions of the Syrian monarchs with India of which we have any account. Nor can we either fix with accuracy the time, or describe the manner, in which their possessions in India were wrested from them. It is probable that they were obliged to abandon that country soon after the death of Seleucus, which happened forty-two years after the decease of Alexander. The petty kings of Bactria continued to carry on military operations in India with considerable success. Their country was separated from India by the mountainous range whence both the Indus and the Oxus flow : and recovering possession of the district near the mouth of the Indus which Alexander had subdued, they penetrated far into the interior of the country. They held peaceable possession of their conquest, until, about one hundred and twenty-six years before the Christian era, a powerful horde of Tartars wrested it from them. Driven by necessity

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C

CHAP.

I.

Ptolemy Soter, king of Egypt, prosecutes his commercial designs with success. Alexandria becomes the emporium of the world.

from their native seat on the confines of China, and obliged to move towards the West by the pressure of a more numerous body that rolled on behind them, they passed the Jaxartes, and pouring in upon Bactria, like an irresistible torrent, overwhelmed that kingdom, and put an end to the dominion of the Greeks there, after it had been established near one hundred and thirty years.

19. Our attention is next turned to Ptolemy Soter, king of Egypt, whose exertions to carry into effect Alexander's commercial schemes, proved more successful than those of his cotemporary, Seleucus, in prosecuting their master's designs of conquest in the East. Under Ptolemy's auspices and vigilance, Egypt soon became the seat of an intercourse with India that promised to be successful and permanent; and it is not without admiration that we observe how soon and how regularly the commerce with the East came to be carried on by that very channel, in which the sagacity of Alexander destined it to flow. Ptolemy, when established in the empire of Egypt, fixed the seat of his government in Alexandria; and the celebrity of its mart, and the immunities which the king granted to traders of all nations, soon attracted vast numbers of foreigners, and induced them to take up their abode in that capital. Ptolemy was one of Alexander's most confidential officers, and he knew that his masters' chief object in founding Alexandria was to secure the advantages arising from the commerce with India. The king of Egypt showed that he was able to appreciate this design, and knew how to render the advantages of his situation available for its accomplishment. Alexandria, commanding the commerce with

the East and the West, soon became the emporium of the world. The Egyptians might now be called a maritime nation, and there was better prospect of their continuing to pay attention to nautical pursuits than under the reign of Sesostris. For the protection of their shipping, Ptolemy built a magnificent light-house on the Island of Pharos, at the mouth of the harbour of Alexandria, which was esteemed one of the seven wonders of the world. A long and prosperous reign enabled him to bring his design to some degree of maturity ; and in the year before Christ 284, he was succeeded by a son, Ptolemy Philadelphus, who entered with no less ardour into all his father's commercial arrangements.

20. In this reign the trade with India began to revive at Tyre, its ancient mart. But the King of Egypt, in order to retain this lucrative monopoly, projected, and indeed commenced, the formation of a spacious canal between the Red Sea and the eastern branch of the Nile, by means of which, had it been completed, the productions of India might have been conveyed to Alexandria wholly by water. When, from some cause which cannot now be ascertained, this project failed, Ptolemy Philadelphus built a city on the western coast of the Red Sea, to which he gave the name of Berenice. The site of this city was well chosen ; the goods from India were transported from Berenice to Coptos by land, about two hundred and fifty-eight Roman miles, through the desert of Thebais. From Coptos they were conveyed to the Nile, about three miles distant, by means of a navigable canal, and thence carried down the stream to Alexandria. In this channel the intercourse between the East and West continued to be

Ptolemy
Philadelphus ; his
judicious
measures to
secure the
Indian
trade.

CHAP.

I.

● Limits of the Egyptians' navigation eastward.

carried on during two hundred and fifty years, that is to say, as long as Egypt remained an independent kingdom.

21. It is not known how far the Egyptian voyagers proceeded along the coast of India; but they appear for a considerable time to have limited their commerce to that part of the country which Alexander had visited and subdued. As their vessels were small, they sailed near the shore; so that their voyages must have been circumscribed within comparatively narrow limits, and under the Ptolemies no considerable progress was made in the discovery of India. Some writers maintain that they stretched as far as the northern part of the Malabar coast; yet this they allow to have been the extent of their progress. It seems very doubtful, however, whether they proceeded so far, or even advanced beyond the mouth of the Indus.

Persians open a commercial intercourse with India by land.

22. During this period, the Persians were no less desirous than the people around them to possess the valuable productions and rich manufactures of India. Averse to navigation, they left to the Egyptians the undisputed monopoly of the commerce by sea; while they transported the commodities of India on camels from the banks of the Indus to those of the Oxus and the Caspian Sea: and thence, by means of navigable rivers and canals, or by land-carriage, they conveyed them to all parts of the Persian dominions.

Romans, under Augustus Cæsar, become possessed of the entire commerce. Universal peace.

23. Such were the channels of intercourse with India by sea and land, while the empires of Egypt and Persia continued to be governed by their own sovereigns: but all this power and these resources, together with the other known parts of the world, were soon to be concentrated in one government. The time

drew near for the advent of Him, whose appearance was to bring glad tidings of great joy to all people. As the consummation of His reign on earth is to be universal peace ; so all nations were at peace at the time of His appearing. The arms of Rome, after many severe contests and frequent alternations of victory and defeat, at last triumphed successively over Sicily and Carthage, Greece and Syria ; and finally, Alexandria was taken by Octavius thirty years before the birth of Jesus Christ, and Egypt reduced into the form of a Roman province. Three years after, by a decree of the Roman senate, Octavius obtained the proud title of Augustus Cæsar, and an absolute exemption from the laws ; an elevation which none before had legally occupied, so that he was properly the first Roman emperor. Left without a rival in the world, he shut the temple of Janus, in token of universal peace.

B. C.
27.

B. C.
A.

24. In that year Christ was born. It had been revealed seven hundred years before, that He should make His first appearance in Bethlehem :¹ and the Providence of God so overruled the proceedings of the Roman emperor, that his attention to the internal arrangement of his vast dominions, compelled the mother of the Messiah to journey from Nazareth, where she dwelt, to Bethlehem, previous to the birth of her miraculous child. The event is thus recorded in Holy Writ.—“ And it came to pass in those days, that there went out a decree from Cæsar Augustus, that all the world should be taxed. And all went to be taxed, every one to his own city. And Joseph also went up from Galilee, out of the city of Nazareth, into Judæa, unto the city of David, which is called Beth-

These events lead to the birth of Jesus Christ at Bethlehem.

¹ Micah v. 2.

CHAP.
I.

lehem, (because he was of the house and lineage of David) to be taxed with Mary his espoused wife, being great with child. And so it was, that, while they were there, the days were accomplished that she should be delivered. And she brought forth her first-born son, and wrapped him in swaddling clothes, and laid him in a manger ; because there was no room for them in the inn."¹

A manifest arrangement of Divine Providence worthy of our grateful adoration.

25. Who can bring his mind to doubt whether all this was the arrangement of a wise and almighty Being? Who can believe that these events concurred accidentally to bring to pass a prediction so ancient and so circumstantially given? Who can think that there is nothing worthy of special remark in the circumstances attending the Redeemer's birth? Surely the same God, whose infinite wisdom ordained and foretold the wondrous event, brought it to pass by His all-pervading power. It is written, "Known unto God are all his works from the beginning of the world ;"² and the devout Christian verily believes, that he remembers "the former things of old ;" "declaring the end from the beginning, and from ancient times the things that are not yet done, saying, My counsel shall stand, and I will do all my pleasure." For He is "God, and there is none else ;" He is "God, and there is none like" Him.³

Such was the position of the world when the Sun of Righteousness arose upon it with healing in His wings.⁴ "He came a light to lighten the Gentiles, and the glory of His people Israel."⁵ If 'an undevout astronomer is mad ;' what shall be said of an undevout historian? If *he* is

¹ Luke ii. 1—7.² Acts xv. 18.³ Isa. xlv. 9, 10.⁴ Malachi iv. 2.⁵ Luke ii. 31, 32,

denied the title of a rational being, who can contemplate without devotion the harmony of the celestial spheres; what right can that man have to the name, who can regard without piety and gratitude a succession of circumstances so much more within our range of observation, and bringing about a result so interesting to the human race? To elevate a mind like this, and teach it to contemplate the sublimities of religion, demands supernatural power and instruction. In such a case, the Redeemer's own question is quite in point.—“If I have told you earthly things, and ye believe not, how shall ye believe, if I tell you of heavenly things?”¹

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A.

26. Thus far we have seen how Divine Providence had progressively opened the way, and prepared facilities, for the universal diffusion of that light with which the Redeemer was to illumine the world. The active pursuits of commerce were rapidly bringing the eastern and western worlds into closer union with each other. The Romans were no less desirous to obtain the productions of India than the nations they had subdued, and their thirst for those luxuries increased with their power to command them. For many ages they continued to flow through the two channels projected by Alexander, and opened by his successors: but as these modes of conveyance did not adequately supply the growing demands of Rome for the commodities of the East, a third medium of communication was opened between Mesopotamia and other provinces on the banks of the Euphrates, and those parts of Syria and Palestine which lay near the Mediterranean. By this route Abraham, upwards of 2000 years before, journeyed from “Ur of the Chaldees, to

Romans prosecute the Indian trade with activity. They open a third channel of communication through Mesopotamia; Solomon traded with the East by the same route.

¹ John iii. 12.

CHAP.
I.

go, at the command of God into the land of Canaan.”¹ Solomon, when he turned his attention to commerce, considered this station of so much importance, that he built a city in the desert of Syria, towards the Euphrates, to facilitate his intercourse with the East. To this city he gave the Syriac name of Tadmor,² which subsequently received the Greek name of Palmyra, both appellations referring to the beauty and abundance of the palm tree which grew there. Under the Romans, the city of Palmyra became a place of great importance; and considering the natural disadvantages of its situation, its opulence can be attributed only to the vast extent of its commerce.

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50.
Hippalus
opens a direct
communication
with India
across the
Arabian sea.

27. These modes of intercourse with India continued with little variation, until about the fiftieth year of the Christian era, at which time a discovery was made that materially shortened the voyage from Egypt, and rapidly led to a more extensive knowledge of the continent and islands of the East. Hitherto, as already described, their small coasting vessels had crept along the northern shore of the Arabian Sea. In the course of their voyages, the Greek and Egyptian pilots could not fail to observe the regular shifting of the periodical winds, now called Monsoons, which blow with little variation from the north-east and south-west at different seasons of the year. Encouraged by attending to this circumstance, Hippalus, the commander of an Egyptian vessel engaged in the Indian trade, ventured, about this time, to relinquish the slow and circuitous course hitherto taken; and boldly stretching from the mouth of the Arabian Gulf across the ocean, he was

¹ Gen. xi. 31.

² 1 Kings ix. 18.

carried by the south-west monsoon to Musiris, a harbour on the western coast of India. This was the greatest adventure of navigation that had hitherto been made by the Egyptian traders, and the passage thus opened continued to be the best communication by sea between the eastern and western nations, during the next fourteen centuries. The voyage from the mouth of the Arabian Gulf to Musiris was performed in forty days.

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50.

28. It is uncertain at what part of the Malabar coast this first emporium of India was situated; but the opinion now generally adopted is, that it was somewhere between Goa and Tellicherry. The elder Pliny describes this harbour, and that of Barace, which was not far distant from it, as very incommodious for trade, in consequence of the shallowness of the water. This inconvenience would induce the merchants to look out for a more convenient port, and they soon found one on the same coast. Its name was Barygaza, and Strabo's description of its approach and situation corresponds with that of Baroach, on the great river Nerbudda, a few miles north of Surat. This soon became a mart of far more consideration than Musiris, carrying on an extensive commerce with the vessels of Egypt, and bartering the productions of the East for the manufactures of the West. A thirst for gain, excited by the increasing facilities for its acquisition; and the spirit of research, awakened by the accounts of those distant regions brought home by different voyagers, led the active and enterprising Romans to extend their survey of the Indian coasts. The elder Pliny, who lived about fifty years after Strabo, added to the geographical information already possessed, an account of the Island of Ceylon,

Description
of the In-
dian coast
then known.

CHAP.
I.Ptolemy's
Geography
of India.

which he calls Taprobane.¹ But it is to Ptolemy we are chiefly indebted for an account of the knowledge that was soon afterwards acquired of the countries still further to the eastward.

29. Ptolemy wrote about eighty years after the elder Pliny. Though he never visited the East, yet, residing in Alexandria at a period when the trade with India was carried on there with great activity, he was favourably situated for obtaining information from persons who had visited that country, and was indefatigable in collecting materials for his geography. Considering the infancy of the science, we cannot be surprised to find his geographical delineations of the places he described very erroneous. Nevertheless, they are sufficiently accurate to convey an idea to what extent those regions were known at that early period. His description of the eastern coast of the Indian continent, as far as the river Ganges, is more correct than might have been expected; and it favours the inference we have drawn, that he received his accounts of it from voyagers who had themselves surveyed those parts. But his delineations of the regions beyond are too imperfect to warrant such a conclusion, and lead to the conjecture, that the persons from whom he collected his information, received it themselves from the native traders who brought the commodities of those distant countries to the marts of India. This observation applies to his Golden Chersonesus, supposed to be the peninsula of Malacca, the eastern boundary of the bay of Bengal. In that case, the great bay which he describes to the eastward, would be the Gulf of Siam. He speaks of Catigara as the utmost limit of navi-

¹ For a more particular account of this island, see Chap. III. of the present Book.

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gation in those times, though he mentions a place beyond, which he calls Thinæ, or Sinæ Metropolis. This is the most remote spot named in his geography, and it has been conjectured, from the similarity in the name, to be some port in China. M. D'Anville concludes, and his conclusion seems to be more probable, that the situation of Sin-hoa, in the western part of Cochin China, corresponds with Ptolemy's description of the site of Sinæ Metropolis. This point must be left for those interested in the inquiry to determine. It is enough for the purpose of this history to have noticed the probable boundary of the navigation eastward at that early period.

Besides this vast extent of coast, Ptolemy has described the island of Ceylon, or Taprobane, on the western, and the Andaman and Nicobar islands on the eastern side of the bay of Bengal.

30. While the Romans were thus extending their researches in this direction by sea, they were no less active in pursuit of the same object by land. The trade carried on with India through the provinces North of Syria, as already described, was continued with great activity, and in the course of a few years it extended to the borders of China. The Romans then endeavoured to render their intercourse with the country more secure by entering into a negotiation with one of the monarchs of that great empire. It is worthy of remark, that this information is derived, not from Greek or Roman, but from Chinese historians, who record¹ "that Antoun (the Emperor Marcus Antoninus) the king of the people of the Western Ocean, sent

Romans enter into negotiation with the emperor of China, to which country they penetrated by land.

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¹ *Memoire sur les Liaisons et le Commerce des Romains, avec les Tartares et les Chinois, par M. de Guignes. Mem. de Literat. xxxii. 355 &c. Robertson's Disquisition, p. 78.*

CHAP.
I.

The extent
of the know-
ledge of the
East in the
second cen-
tury.

an embassy with this view to Oun-ti, who reigned over China in the hundred and sixty-sixth year of the Christian æra."

31. The farthest point East in this direction to which their knowledge extended, was a town which Ptolemy calls Sera Metropolis, which appears, from various circumstances, to have been in the same situation with Kant-chcou, a city of some note in Chen-si, the most westerly province of the Chinese empire. This industrious and intelligent geographer collected some general information concerning various nations towards the North, which, according to the position he gives them, occupied parts of the great plain of Tartary, extending considerably beyond Lassa, the capital of Tibet.

Such were the limits of the eastern countries known to the Romans in the second century of the Christian æra. They, and the powers who successively followed them in the sovereignty of the western world, were for many ages content with the commercial advantages resulting from the connexion with India, all thoughts of conquest being relinquished until the fifteenth century, and the nations of Europe aiming at nothing more, than to secure an intercourse of trade with that opulent country.

This rapid sketch of the history of events that led to the opening of India to the nations of the West, may serve to dispel the mystery which, to some persons, seems to hang over the earlier records of European intercourse with the East. It may also, in some measure, enable the reader to judge of the probability of the account next to be given of the introduction of Christianity into those distant regions.¹

¹ The reader, who may wish to fill up the outline described

in the text, will find ample materials for the purpose in the following works ;

Strabo's Geography ; Arrian's History of the Indies ; Pliny's Natural History ; Ptolemy's Geography.

The accounts of these writers are involved in much obscurity, which M. D'Anville has endeavoured to remove. In the execution of his task, he has shown considerable diligence and ability, and many of his conclusions are now generally adopted.

His principal works are, *Limites du Monde connues Anciens au-delà du Gange*. *Mem. de Literat. Ant. de l'Inde*.

This chapter is drawn up chiefly from Robertson's *Historical Disquisition*, concerning the knowledge which the ancients had of India, in which work may be found a very useful digest of the above-mentioned authors. Rollin's *Ancient History* will furnish a still more circumstantial account of the principal events here related.

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CHAPTER II.

INTRODUCTION OF CHRISTIANITY INTO INDIA.

Improbability of any Apostles having preached in India.

1. WHILE mankind were establishing the commercial intercourse between Europe and Asia, described in the preceding chapter, the providence of God was preparing the way for the propagation of the Gospel in the East. At what precise period it was introduced into India, is uncertain. Tradition dates it as early as the apostolic age, and ascribes it to the preaching of Apostles; this, however, is very doubtful, as will presently be shown. There is satisfactory evidence indeed that it was carried to India at a very early period; but, considering the tedious mode of communication with that country, and the ancients' limited knowledge of its inhabitants until towards the close of the first century, it is not probable that any of the Apostles of our Lord embarked on such a voyage. Instead, however, of prejudging this interesting question, let us see what the earliest historians of the Church have written upon the subject.

The account of St. Bartholomew's preaching there incredible.

2. Eusebius, the father of Ecclesiastical history, relates, that St. Bartholomew preached the Gospel in India.¹ This assertion is repeated

¹ Eccl. Hist. lib. v. c. 10. Eusebius lived in the fourth century. He was consecrated Bishop of Casarea, in Palestine, A. D. 313, and died A. D. 338. His history of the Church of Christ is carried on from the commencement to the year 309.

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166.

by Socrates,¹ who, referring to the division of the gentile world among the Apostles which Eusebius had related,² says, that India was assigned to St. Bartholomew.³ He describes this country as situated upon the confines of Ethiopia, calls it the innermost India, and relates that it was inhabited by several barbarous nations, who spake numerous languages. From this description it is uncertain what precise country he meant ; but "no doubt," says Cave," it was the Asian Æthiopia :"⁴ that is, the country beyond Ethiopia, with which the merchants of Alexandria carried on the extensive commerce which has been described in the former chapter.

That St. Bartholomew was ever in India is very problematical indeed. Eusebius does not name that Apostle in his account of the division of the heathen nations to which Socrates refers ; and it is only incidentally that he alludes, in a subsequent part of his history, to the journey in question.⁵ Socrates also mentions it without reference to any authority for his assertion, and asserts, at the same time, that India was not enlightened with the doctrines of Christianity before the reign of Constantine the Great.⁶

¹ Socrates followed in the fifth century, taking up the history where Eusebius left off, and continuing it to the year 440.

² Ecc. Hist. lib. iii. c. 1.

³ Socrates Scholasticus. Ecc. Hist. lib. i. c. 19. Rufinus, Tillemont, Baronius, and others after them, have followed in the wake of this assertion, without appearing to have investigated its probability. Fabricius. Lux Evangelii, c. 36, p. 626.

⁴ Cave's Apostles and Fathers. St. Bartholomew, fol. edit. A. D. 1677.

⁵ Euseb. Eccles. Hist. lib. v. c. 10. Vide the Note of Valesius in loco.

⁶ Socrates. Ecc. Hist. lib. i. c. 19.

CHAP.
II.

After an attentive investigation of the subject, I do not hesitate to affirm, that the whole story is built upon a foundation too slender to sustain it. It appears to have originated in a vague rumour, that the Gospel of St. Matthew was found in India about the beginning of the third century. Eusebius mentions this as a report, without attempting to corroborate it. Du Pin¹ and others speak of it in similar terms: and Milner, though he deemed it worth mentioning as a current tradition, yet much doubted its truth.² Such a report, however, would be received without much hesitation in a credulous age; and those who believed it would find little difficulty in imagining, or crediting, the story of St. Bartholomew's visit to India, in order to account for the alleged discovery of the Gospel in those parts.

The story
of St.
Thomas also
unworthy of
credit.

3. The tradition which attributes to the Apostle Thomas the introduction of Christianity into India, is of very early date: but, though now more generally credited than that which ascribes it to St. Bartholomew, it derives less support from authentic history. Eusebius does not even mention it. That historian says, that tradition assigns to St. Thomas the region of Parthia;³ but he does not appear anywhere to allude to this Apostle's travels and preaching in India. Socrates also is silent on the subject, and the same may be said of all the earlier historians of the church. Cave takes his account of St. Thomas' journeys in the East from Nicephorus, a Greek historian of the fourteenth century; and also from the Portuguese, "in want,"

¹ Du Pin's Eccl. Hist. fol. edit. 1693, p. 62.

² Milner's Church Hist. cent. 3. c. 3.

³ Eccl. Hist. lib. iii. c. 1.

he admits, "of better evidence from antiquity."¹

La Croze has drawn up the following account of this tradition from all the authorities he could collect, but declares, at the same time, that it does not appear to be entitled to credit.²

¹ Cave's *Apostles and Fathers*, pp. 186, 187. The Abbé Fleury pronounces Metophrastus, *Nicephorus*, and other writers of about the same day, as of little authority in questions of such antiquity. *Eccles. Hist. Dissertation 1st.*

² The following note, taken from Turner's *History of the Anglo-Saxons*, vol. ii. p. 147, will convey some idea of the puerile character of this tradition. "In the Saxon life of St. Thomas, in MS. Calig. A. 14., which is ascribed to Elfric in Jul. E. 7., the legendary account there is, 'The Saviour himself came to him from heaven, and said to him,' 'A king of the Indians, who is called Gundosorus, will send his geresca to Syria's land to seek some labourer who is skilful in arts. I will soon send thee forth with him.' Thomas answered, 'Send me whither thou wilt, except to the Indians.' But, on the command to go being repeated, he assented; and, when the regal officer came, they went together to the ship, and reared their sail and proceeded with the wind; and they sailed forth then seven nights before they reached a shore, but it would be long to tell all the wonders that he did there. They came next to the king in India, and Abbanes boldly brought Thomas to the speech of the king, who said to him, 'Canst thou build me a kingly mansion in the Roman manner?' Thomas tried and succeeded, and had then liberty to preach, and baptized, and constructed a church, and Migdonia, the king's wife's sister, believed what he taught."—Cott. MSS. Calig. A. 14. pp. 112—118.

The native Christians of the Roman Church relate a miraculous story of St. Thomas which, probably, refers to this building. "The sea having cast up a tree of a vast bulk, the king, who was desirous to use it in the building of a house, had employed a great number of men and elephants to bring it from thence, but in vain, the wood being not to be moved from the place. St. Thomas standing by, told the king, that if he would present him with the piece of wood, he would carry it alone to the city, then ten leagues from the shore. The king looking upon him as a mad man, told him, He should do with it what he pleased. Whereupon St.

“ In the division of all the parts of the world which was made among the holy Apostles, India fell to the lot of St. Thomas, who, after having established Christianity in Arabia Felix and in the Island of Dioscoride, now called Socotora, arrived at Cranganore, where the principal king of the coast of Malabar then resided. It was there that the fabulous adventures happened, of which we read in this Apostle's life, written by the pretended Abdias of Babylon. The holy Apostle having established many churches at Cranganore, passed to Coulan,¹ a celebrated town of the same coast, where he converted many persons to Christianity. Having departed to the other coast, now known by the name of Coromandel, he stopped at Meliapore, a town which the Europeans call St. Thomé, where he is said to have converted the king and all the people. He went from thence to China, and remained in a town called Camballé, where he made numerous conversions, and built many churches.

“ St. Thomas returned from China to Meliapore, where the great success that attended

“ Thomas, tying his girdle to one of the branches, and making the sign of the cross, drew the whole tree after him with a great deal of ease, followed by a vast number of people: and coming to the city, erected a stone cross there, telling the spectators, That whenever the sea should rise up to that place, God would send certain strangers from far distant places to settle the Christian religion here. This the Portuguese would have to be verified by their coming there;” and there is reason to suspect that they are the inventors of the story. *Baldaeus' Description of Malabar and Coromandel*, c. 20. *Churchill's Voyages*, &c. vol. iii. p. 575. *Baldaeus* refers to Lucena, Osorius, and Baronius, (tom. i.) for an account of a cross made by this Apostle's blood, “ and a vast number of miracles wrought by it.”

¹ Quilon.

“his labours among the heathen excited against him the hatred and envy of two Brahmins, who are the priests of the idolatrous superstition of India. These two men stirred up the people, who combined to stone the holy apostle. After his execution, one of the Brahmins, observing that he still breathed, pierced him with a lance, which put an end to his life.”

“I shall not lose time,” says the historian, in refuting this narration of the death of the holy apostle, which is not apparently less fabulous than the coming of St. Thomas into India.”

I should follow the example of this author, and immediately pass on to more authentic records, were it not that several writers and tra-

¹ La Croze, pp. 39, 40. This author refers to the Portuguese historian, A. Gouvea, an authority implicitly followed by Asseman and other Romish writers who have repeated this legend. Asseman refers indeed to other authorities of greater antiquity, as the following note will show: but it will be seen how little they support the particular tradition which they are adduced to sustain.

“Thomas, cui Judæ nomen fuisse, ex Ephræmo Syro et Tabulariis Edessenis constat, non Syrorum modo et Chaldæorum, sed Parthorum etiam, Persarum, Medorum Indorumque Orientalium Apostolus fuit. Origines, (Lib. iii. in Genes.) Euseb. (Lib. iii. Histor. Eccl. cap. 1.) Rufinus, (Lib. i. cap. 9), Auctor libri Recognitionem, (Lib. ix. cap. 29), Socrates, (Lib. i. cap. 15.) aliique, Parthiam Thomæ obtigisse scribunt. Persidem Fortunatus Parthiæ substituit. (Lib. i. Carm. 1.) Parthiam, Persidem, et Indiam Thomæ assignat Hippolytus. (In Synopsi), Nazianzenus, (Orat. 21), et martyrologi omnes, (Baron. in not. ad Martyrolog. Roman. 21 Decemb.) Loca prædicationis Sophronius apud Hieronymum sic recenset. *Thomas Apostolus, quemadmodum traditum est nobis, Parthis, et Medis, et Persis, et Carminis, et Hyrcanis, et Bactris, et Margis, prædicavit Evangelium Domini*, (Sophronius, cap. 8). Asseman, Bib. Orient. Tom. iii. pars. 2. p. 25.

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vellers of the last and present century, have given more credit to this tradition than it appears to deserve.¹ A very short acquaintance with the Greek and Latin authors who have preserved and amplified it, will be quite enough to satisfy most readers of their extreme credulity, whatever credit may be thought due to this particular tradition. Many of them seem to have treasured up, as a sacred relique, every report that floated in the atmosphere of ignorance and superstition.

Some persons have thought it quite as probable that St. Thomas should visit the eastern, as that St. Paul should travel to the western extremity of the regions then known. But this opinion must surely have been formed without reference to the comparative state of the two hemispheres, during the first century of the Christian era. The Roman arms had penetrated even as far as Britain, and every part of the continent of Europe was accessible to an ordinary traveller. Not so the continent of India. It has been shown above, that until about the middle of the first century, the voyage to India was long and tedious; and considering the infancy of the commerce with that country, it is not probable that any but traders would venture so far eastward before the second century. The extension of the story to China greatly diminishes its credibility, as it is very doubtful indeed whether any Egyptian or Roman

¹ " Bishop Heber, (*Journal*, Vol. ii. p. 278), and Archdeacon Robinson, (*Last Days of Bishop Heber*, p. 317), incline to favour the claim of the Syro-Malabaric Church to this apostolic origin." Dean Pearson's *Life of Swartz*, Vol. i. p. 4. The author followed by these and other writers inclined to adopt this opinion, is Paulinus, author of "*Orientalis Christiana*," see pp. 127—145.

navigator penetrated beyond the river Ganges for several ages after the discovery of India.

This legend is not universally received by Romish writers: The learned Tillemont, in his ecclesiastical history of the first six ages,¹ treats the whole story as worthy of little or no credit. Eusebius Renaudot, in his translation of the travels of two Mahomedans into India and China in the ninth century, says,² "Notwithstanding all that has been written by the Portuguese, and others, about St. Thomas preaching in China, it can never stand upon the feeble support of far-fetched conjecture, and bare probability." Then, a few pages further, he accounts with great candour for the origin of the story.³ "Two or three authors, who but copy from each other, suffice to give birth to a notion which spreads unexamined by those who follow them: this throws a mist over history, and gives an opportunity to confound truth with falsehood, and what is certain with what is mere conjecture. For example, Father Trigaut, misunderstanding some passages of Syriac,⁴ declares it very probable that St. Thomas preached in China. A few years afterwards they find the Chinese and Syriac inscription, which talks of a mission from Judæa or Syria; whereupon it was by some asserted, that the persons, therein-mentioned, must have been St. Thomas; and

¹ Tom. i. pp. 284—290. Fol. ed.

² Preface, p. xxviii.

³ Id. p. xxxv.

⁴ In the *Beit Gaza*, or *Breviary* of the Syrian Church, where these words occur. *By St. Thomas the error of Idolatry has been confounded in the Indies. By St. Thomas the Chinese and Ethiopians have been converted to the knowledge of the truth. By St. Thomas the kingdom of Heaven hath taken its flight, and ascended quite up to China.* Vide *Memoirs of Matthew Ricci*, one of the first missionaries to China. E. Renaudot's *Inquiry into the origin of the Christian Religion in China*, p. 77. London ed. 1733.

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at once they prick you down the track he must have followed, and give you a map to convince you it was so. "But these systems," he asserts, "are confessedly an absurdity: yet most who have touched on this matter in our times, do, upon no other testimony than Trigaut has offered, lay it down as an indubitable truth, that St. Thomas himself preached in China; it is not doubted, says one of the last of them, but St. Thomas preached the faith in the Indies." Then, after quoting what this author¹ asserts respecting the introduction of Christianity into China, he thus remarks upon the legend in reference to India.² "It is true indeed, the common tradition of the Malabar Churches has it, that St. Thomas preached in the Indies, and the same has been admitted into the Roman Martyrology, where it is said he suffered martyrdom at Calamina: but there is no memorial left of any city so called in those parts, and the conjectures which some of the learned have advanced, concerning this name, are quite intolerable. Father Kircher pretends we must read Calurmina, instead of Calamina, and that the word signifies *upon a stone*; because in that country they still show a stone figured with some crosses, and other ensigns of Christianity, and upon this stone the Malabars tell you, he was pierced by a brahmin."

The Abbe Fleury, another candid historian of the Roman Church, has spoken of the ac-

¹ Mem. de la Chin. tom. ii. p. 195.

² Renaudot's Inquiry, &c., pp. 79, 80. It would answer little purpose to enter here upon the discussion that has been raised about the name of a place mentioned by the two Mahomedan travellers as well known on the shores of India. It is called *Betuma*, which has been interpreted, the house, or church of St. Thomas.

tions of both St. Bartholomew and St. Thomas as involved in great uncertainty :¹ and the more carefully the two questions are consulted, the better will the intelligent reader be satisfied, that neither of them rests on a valid foundation. Protestant historians have taken a similar view of them. We have seen that no one credits the story about St. Bartholomew ; and little more can be said for the legend of St. Thomas. The learned Fabricius, quoting the earliest authorities that at all bear upon it, classes it with other *questionable* traditions.² After citing the passage from Sophronius, which speaks of that apostle's falling at Calamina, he expresses himself as dubiously about this place as did Renaudot.³ The two chief protestant historians of the Church, Mosheim and Milner, take no notice of the subject : and since the latter has

¹ Fleury's Discourse on Ecclesiastical History, p. 42. London edit. 1721. See also his Ecclesiastical History on the same subject.

² Traditiones minus certæ. Lux Evangelii. 4to edit. 1731. pp. 108—110.

³ *Calaminam* existere tantum in Utopia et cerebro male feriato, scribit Steph. le Moyne notis ad varia sacra, p. 1060, qui suspicatur *καλιρόνη* sive Edessam sub illo nomine latitare, ubi S. Thomæ ostentatæ fuere reliquiæ. Kircherus vero Chinæ illustratæ c. 79. *Calaminam* interpretatur, *Maliapuram* S. Thomæ civitatem dictam a Lusitanis, Narsingæ ultra Indum fluvium metropolin, cum veteres ad citeriorem modo Indiam Thomam penetrasse testentur, unde illi sententiæ fidem detrahit præter laudatum Lemonium Samuel Basnage ad A. C. 46. n. 32. seq.

Baldæus agrees with Father Kircher in his interpretation of *Calurmina*, that it is not the name of a place, but merely descriptive of the spot where the apostle is said to have been martyred, *upon a rock*, or stone. In the Tamul language, which is spoken on the Coromandel coast, *callu* or *calur* is a stone, and *mel*, *minu*, or *midu*, upon. Baldæus' Description, &c., ch. xx. Churchill's Voyages, &c., Vol. iii. p. 575.

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referred to the story of St. Bartholomew, it may be concluded that he deemed the legend of St. Thomas even less credible. La Croze rejects it, and at the same time accounts for its origin in a satisfactory manner, as will soon appear: and he has been followed in his conclusion by an intelligent writer in the *Asiatic Researches*,¹ who declares, that "this story is supported by no historical proof whatever." Baldæus credits the tradition indeed, being, as he expresses it, "the most secure way, because," as he thinks, "founded upon no small probabilities:" but he does not give the grounds of these "probabilities," to enable his readers to judge of them; and all the authorities which he has quoted he agrees to set aside as "uncertain relations." However desirous we may be to establish so interesting a fact as the visit of St. Thomas to India, yet historic truth is too important to admit an assumption, unsupported as this is by the faintest vestige of authentic history; and in itself, I must continue to think it most improbable.

Probable
origin of the
tradition
about him.

4. While, however, we reject this account as applied to the South of India, we admit that there would be much less improbability in the tradition if supposed to refer to the northern provinces bordering on the banks of the Indus. There is no question that the several ancient writers referred to by Asseman, Fabricius, and others, speak of St. Thomas' travels in a way that proves, at least, the antiquity of the tradition that he visited India: and this may be easily accounted for. Assuming the truth of Eusebius' account of the division of the Gentile

¹ F. Wrede, esq., Account of St. Thomé Christians on the coast of Malabar. *Asiatic Researches*, Vol. vii. p. 364.

world among the Apostles, Parthia was assigned to St. Thomas, and he might, without much difficulty, have visited some of the upper provinces of Hindoostan. For Parthia was bounded on the East by the river Indus; and it has been shown, in the former chapter, that since the days of Alexander the Great, a constant communication had been maintained with India in this direction, and that the Romans, in the first century of the Christian era, carried on a brisk trade through the same channel. It is easy, therefore, to imagine, that the Apostles' holy zeal for the glory of his Lord and for the salvation of the heathen, would move him to endeavour to evangelize the regions bordering upon his province. Origen, who lived in the third century, says expressly, that this Apostle preached in Parthia, Media, Caramania, and Bactriana. Though he does not mention India, yet the last-named kingdom was bounded on the East by Indo-Scythia and the country of the Massagetæ, through which the Indus flowed: and whether the apostle himself crossed that river, or sent others to preach there, the proximity of his province may be thought sufficient to account for his receiving the appellation of *The Apostle of India*. This is the utmost that can be conjectured on the subject; for, after all, it is mere conjecture: but it has some show of probability, which cannot be said for the extraordinary tales of St. Thomas' voyages and travels in the South and East of India and China.¹

¹ Some have carried the story so far, as to make this Apostle pass over, some way or other, even to the Brazils. Vide *Historica Ecclesia*, &c. See *Asiatic Researches*, Vol. vii. p. 364, &c.

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The mass of legendary matter which has been mixed up with this story is wholly unworthy of credit. Whatever foundation there may have been for the tradition as preserved by the earlier Christians in India, yet, as exaggerated and dressed up by more modern writers, it is fabulous in the extreme. That it is not wholly without foundation in the annals of the church in the East, is readily conceded; as no less than three persons bearing the name of Thomas occur in the early history of the Indian Christians, to whom the different parts of the tradition may be applied. It would be premature here further to anticipate our narrative; but it is important that the reader should bear this fact in mind, that he may be on his guard against the conjectures and the marvellous legends with which the history of Christianity in India has been clouded and encumbered.

Tradition of
the Eunuch
of Ethiopia
preaching at
Ceylon.

5. Sophronius,¹ bishop of Jerusalem, a Greek writer of the seventh century, mentions, that the Ethiopian eunuch whose conversion by Philip is recorded in the Acts of the Apostles, sailed to the island of Taprobane² (Ceylon) where he preached the Gospel: that he is reported to have suffered martyrdom there, and to have received an honourable burial. This also the learned Fabricius³ has classed with his questionable traditions, though it is perhaps as worthy of credit as that relating to St. Thomas. Cave likewise confirms this account, which he gathered from Dorotheus, and the current traditions of the country.⁴

¹ This writer has just been quoted from Asseman and Fabricius. Vide Du Pin, Vol. vi. p. 17.

² Acts viii. 26—29.

³ Lux Evangelii, p. 115.

⁴ Life of Philip the Deacon.

6. Though we cannot attribute to the church of Christ in India an apostolic origin, yet there are reasonable grounds for assigning to it a date very little posterior to the apostolic age. It is generally believed that St. Mark the evangelist founded the church at Alexandria. Writers are divided in opinion as to the time when he went into Egypt, some affirming that it was in the second, others, in the ninth year of Claudius, and others, in the third of Caligula. This point it is now as difficult as unimportant to determine. In this, however, all are agreed, that he passed the latter years of his life in that country, where he introduced the Gospel, and lived to see the church flourish under his superintendence.¹ It will be remembered, that at this period Alexandria was the emporium of the world. By means of its extensive commerce it had now acquired an importance second only to Rome herself. Like other mercantile towns, its population was composed of the inhabitants of all the nations with which they carried on trade. Of these the Jews formed no inconsiderable portion. There were also vast numbers of strangers, not only from Syria, Lybia, Cilicia, Ethiopia, and Arabia, but also from Bactria, Scythia, Persia, and *India*, who were drawn thither by the attractions of its mart.² Here the Evangelist Mark assembled a numerous church, which, like the first fruits of the Gospel at Jerusalem, would be composed of converts from all the nations which Divine Providence had thus brought together, that they might hear the glad tidings of salvation. They came for the sake of this world's traffic indeed; but they found, in the knowledge of

Probable account of the early origin of the Indian Church through Mark the Evangelist, and founder of the Church of Alexandria.

¹ Eusebius. Ecc. Hist. Lib. ii. ch. 16.

² Fleury. Ecc. Hist. Lib. ii. sect. 5.

the Gospel, infinitely more than they sought, and returned home freighted with the merchandize of heaven.

It is not likely that Mark, who had travelled so much with Paul and Barnabas, in their journeys to spread abroad the kingdom of Christ in the world, should neglect the facilities that his situation afforded him, to send the Gospel to all countries to which he could gain access, either by means of native traders or the members of his own church. It has been seen that the Indian trade was in his time the chief object of attraction at Alexandria; and the progress of Christianity to India at that early period may be traced with some probability.

The populous island of Socotora,¹ in the Arabian Sea, lay about midway between the two countries, and was of considerable importance to the merchants of Alexandria. Alexander the Great, knowing the importance of this station to the furtherance of his commercial designs, removed the native inhabitants, and established there a colony of Greeks, issuing special orders to the neighbouring powers that this colony should be carefully preserved. We are informed that they remained in custody of 'the island until God sent Jesus Christ into the world; when the Greeks of this same isle, being informed concerning his Advent, embraced the Christian faith, as the other Greeks had done before them; and in the profession of this faith they have persevered to this day, as well as all the inhabitants of the other isles.'² By

¹ Called the Isle of Aloes, from the vast quantity and excellent quality of that useful drug which grew upon it. The discovery of this island is considered one of the most important incidents in Alexander's progress. — E. Renaudot.

² This was written in the ninth century by the Mahomedan

whom Christianity was introduced there is uncertain. It has been attributed to St. Thomas,¹ but without any authority being cited in support of the assumption. It is more probable that some Christians of the primitive church of Alexandria, accompanying the Egyptian voyagers sailing to the East, stopped at this island, and preached to its inhabitants the Gospel of Christ: and as this was in the direct course to India, nothing can be more reasonable than to conclude, that while some remained behind at Socotora, others pursued the voyage to the place of the vessel's destination. While the merchants of Alexandria coveted the treasure, and the voluptuous craved the luxuries of the East; devout Christians, indifferent to both, would seek to make the Indians a more ample return for their merchandize than the marts of Egypt could yield. Obtaining information of their country from those Indians who visited Alexandria, they would desire to send them home freighted with a richer treasure than they brought, even the Gospel of salvation. Nor is it likely that they would be content merely to

travellers, whose account of India and China has been already noticed, pp. 91, 92. Marco Paolo relates of this island, that its inhabitants were Christians, and that they had an Archbishop under a Zatholic, who resided at Bagdad; that is, a *Catholico*, or Patriarch of the *Nestorians*. The Portuguese writers, on the contrary, maintain that they are Jacobites, or subject to the Patriarchs of Antioch or Alexandria. When the Portuguese first came to this island, the inhabitants appeared before them with crosses in their hands, to show that they were Christians. (Barros, Dec. 2; lib. 1. c. 3. Purch. p. 778). But Odoardo Barbosa says (p. 292), that, in his time, they had hardly any notion of baptism, and that they had nothing left to distinguish them as Christians but the bare name.—E. Renaudot. Note GG on the two Mahomedan's Travels quoted in the text.

¹ Maffei. *Historia Indica*, Lib. ii. p. 82.

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instruct these strangers, and leave it to them to teach their countrymen on their return. Such a method of propagating the religion which they loved, must have appeared too precarious to satisfy the holy zeal of primitive Christians. Some, inspired by the Spirit that has always animated the faithful missionary's bosom, would cheerfully leave their home, with all its endearments, and go forth to preach among those Gentiles "the unsearchable riches of Christ." "For there were many evangelical preachers of the word even at that time, who, inflamed with a divine zeal, in imitation of the Apostles, contributed their assistance to the enlargement of the Divine Word, and the building up men in the faith."¹ Who those heralds of mercy were, or to what extent the great Head of the Church vouchsafed to prosper their endeavours, the pen of history has not recorded. But this is of little moment. It is enough to know that their names are written in heaven;² and that having diligently sowed the seed of immortal life, they will participate in the joy of those who have already reaped, or shall hereafter reap, its imperishable fruits.³

In this manner then we may account for the introduction of Christianity into India. As nothing is distinctly recorded of the period when it was introduced, or of the circumstances that led to it, there can be no sufficient data for a positive conclusion: and in balancing the probabilities that arise out of the general allusions found in the early annals of the church, he is on the safest side who keeps the most clear of the marvellous.

7. We know that the first Christian mission-

A. D.
200.

¹ Eusebius, Lib. v. ch. 10.

² Luke x. 20.

³ John iv. 36.

aries to India, whoever they were, did not labour in vain, though there appears to be no authentic record of the church they established there before the second century. About that period, Demetrius, bishop of Alexandria, received a message from some natives of that country, earnestly requesting him to send a teacher to instruct them in the faith and doctrines of Christ.¹ It is probable that these Indians were converts, or children of former converts to Christianity, and that they sent their message to Demetrius by some of the vessels that were constantly visiting their shores from Egypt. At that time one Pantænus, a Stoic philosopher who had embraced the Christian religion, presided over the celebrated school at Alexandria. Hearing of the Indians' request, this scholar freely offered himself to the work. Renouncing for a season the honours and emoluments of his situation, regardless of the dangers and difficulties of the voyage, he went forth with a willing mind, to spread abroad the light of life among those who were sitting in the twilight of truth, or in the darkness and shadow of death. This is the teacher who is said to have found in India the Gospel of St. Matthew in Hebrew, which St. Bartholomew was supposed to have carried thither. But, for reasons just stated, this tale appears to have no foundation in fact.

It is not known how long Pantænus was absent, but after his return home, he resumed his public duties as a teacher, and continued to preside over the school at Alexandria. As an expounder of the sacred scriptures, he met with great acceptance ; but whether his preach-

A. D.
200.

Pantænus of
Alexandria
the first mis-
sionary to
India in the
2nd century.

¹ Eusebius, Lib. v. ch. 10. Milner's Ch. Hist. Cent. 3, ch. 3.

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ing was as profitable as acceptable, may well be questioned. He published some commentaries on the Bible, which are lost; so that the only means of forming an opinion of his method of explaining its contents, are contained in the writings of Clemens Alexandrinus, his disciple; and also in the works of Origen and others who were brought up in the same school, and may be supposed to have inculcated the doctrines of their master. From these it appears, that in that age, and in the church to which they belonged, there was a sad declension from the simplicity of scriptural truth. Pantænus himself was more celebrated for his philosophy than his divinity; and some of his most distinguished pupils erred grievously from the faith. Nevertheless, there seems to be sufficient ground for the following favourable opinion that has been formed of his integrity.—“ Candour requires us to look on him as a sincere Christian, whose fruitfulness was yet much checked by that very philosophy for which Eusebius so highly commends him. A blasting wind it surely was: but it did not entirely destroy Christian vegetation in all whom it infected.”¹

Who is not glad to believe thus much of the first Indian missionary on record? Of his exertions and successes in that country we have no account; but we are willing to hope, notwithstanding the disadvantages of his station and habits, and the imperfection of his own creed, that he shone as a light in a dark place, among the idolaters of the East, and was made, through the inspiration of the Holy Spirit, the honoured instrument of guiding many into the way of

¹ Milner, Cent. 3, ch. 3.

salvation. If we cannot attribute to him the enlightened zeal of a missionary of brighter days, we may at least give him credit for motives equally unquestionable. Integrity of purpose in promoting the cause of divine truth, is by no means incompatible with a limited knowledge of its value. That man, indeed, who knows the most of his Redeemer, will love Him the best; and his love will constrain him, in exact proportion to its purity and strength, to follow the Lord Jesus' injunctions.¹ This obedience he will render at every call of Christian duty, but especially will he obey the command to make known the way of God upon earth, His saving health among all nations.² The same principle, however, may actuate a Christian of weaker faith and less enlightened understanding, diligently to employ his single talent in the service of his Lord. Such, we may venture to hope, was the motive of Pantænus, in offering himself to the arduous enterprise of carrying the Gospel to India.

But a question has of late been raised about the country which was the scene of this missionary's labours. It is said, "The doubt respecting the country called India, to which he is stated to have been sent, is most probably to be solved by our concluding that he went to Arabia, and not to that country in the east of Asia which is properly known by the name of India."³ This remark⁴ must not be passed with-

¹ John xiv. 15, 23. ² Psalm lxvii. 2; Mark xvi. 15.

³ History of the Christian Church, by Dr. Edward Burton, late Regius Professor of Divinity in the University of Oxford, p. 252.

⁴ Not indeed that the difficulty was raised by this author. (See Bishop Middleton's Address, &c. Report of the Christian Knowledge Society for 1813, p. 62. Mosheim, Vol. i. p. 149.) But the doubt seems principally to have been as to the *part of India* from which the ambassadors came.—Milner's Church Hist. Vol. i. p. 288.

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out some notice in this place: for it is calculated to depreciate a fact of some consequence in the early history of the Indian church; and the name and station of its author may cause greater importance to be attached to it than he, probably, intended.

The doubt that long hung over the country called India will come more appropriately under discussion at the close of this chapter, when giving an account of another mission. At present we need only remark, that it does not appear that any ancient author felt any such difficulty in the case of Pantænus, and the country he visited: and there is strong collateral evidence in the writings of his favourite pupil and successor, Clemens Alexandrinus, that he went to India proper. This author, alluding to the inhabitants and customs of that region, describes particularly the jogees and brahmins, and speaks of the god Boodhu.

“ ‘There are two descriptions of Indian Gymnosophists, or barbarous philosophers: the one called *Sarmanes*, the other, *Brahmins*. The *Sarmanes* are also called recluses; ² they do not live in towns, and have no houses; they cover their bodies with the bark of trees, and live on fruits. Their only beverage is water, which they drink out of the hollow of their hands. They do not marry, and live after the manner of the *Encratites*.³ The brahmins are those Indians who obey the

¹ Stromat., L. i. p. 529, edit. Potteri. La Croze, Histoire du Christianisme des Indes, Liv. vi. p. 492, 493.

² ἀλλόττοι, Solitaires.

³ i. e. Temperate. These recluses were followers of the heretic Tatian, an unworthy disciple of Justin Martyr. This sect arose towards the end of the second century. They were also called *Continentes*, because they abstained from marriage, the use of wine, and animal food. Other names of the like signification were given to them. Mosheim, cent. 2, part 2, sect. ix.

“ commandments of *Boutta*, whom they honour
 “ as a god, because of the holiness of his life.”
 Can it be doubted that these sarmanes and
 brahmins were the Indian recluses and priests
 of his day? And when we compare them with
 the modern jogees and brahmins of Hindoostan,
 is it not more than probable that he is describ-
 ing the inhabitants of the same country? Then,
 the god *Boutta* that he mentions, was, no
 doubt, the same idol that Jerom¹ and other
 early writers call *Bouddha*, the ninth incarnation
 of the Hindoo god Vishnoo, formerly an object of
 general adoration in India, but now worshipped
 chiefly in Ceylon. Assuming then that Clemens
 is speaking of the inhabitants and idolatries of
 India, from what source is he so likely to have
 derived his information about that country as
 from his master Pantænus, after his return?
 If this does not amount to positive evidence of
 this missionary's having been there, it is at
 least a strong collateral proof of it. To say
 that Rufinus, Jerom, Nicephorus, and other
 early writers, spoke of it as a fact which no one
 at that time thought of doubting, were, perhaps,
 to beg the question; for it would still remain
 to be proved what country they meant by
 India.² But this cannot be objected to the
 opinion of Fabricius, who quotes all the ancient
 authorities on the subject, and styles him the
 Apostle of India:³ nor to that of Niccamp, who
 expressly says, that Pantænus and other per-

¹ Hieronym. Lib. i. adversus Jovinianum, Tom. IV. p. 186, col. 2. Apud *Gymnosophistes Indiæ* quasi per manus hujus opinionis auctoritas traditur, quod *Buddam* principem dogmatis eorum e latere suo virgo generavit. La Croze, pp. 492, 493, also 512, 513.

² See the Note of Valesius upon Eusebius, Lib. v. ch. 10.

³ PANTÆNUS, INDIE APOSTOLUS. Lux Evangelii, cap. 36, p. 627.

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sons were called from Alexandria to India.¹ For in the time of both these writers, and that of others yet more modern, the name *India* was well understood to mean the country at present so denominated.

With such testimony in support of the fact, we cannot assent to the assertion, that "There is no reason to suppose that Pantænus travelled in the direction of India;" nor to the conjecture, that the southern part of Arabia, which is washed by the waters of the Persian Gulf, was the scene of his labours, and that "the conversion of the inhabitants may have been principally caused by him."² This, if admitted, would reduce it to a question of probability; and there are strong grounds for the opposite opinion, whereas none are produced for that here cited. It has been shown above, that the intercourse between Alexandria and India was open and frequent almost from the commencement of the Christian era, and that there are satisfactory reasons to conclude that Christianity was introduced into that country from Alexandria before the time of Pantænus. In the absence then of all proof that Arabia was the scene of his mission, or of any testimony, or even circumstance, except, perhaps, the mere locality, to favour that notion; we must continue to maintain, that there *is* good reason to conclude that he went to the country now known by the name of *India*.

A. D.
306.

8. The beginning of the fourth century was a new epoch in the History of Christianity; for

¹ Id tamen certum est, jam anno post Christum natum CLXXXVIII, *Pantænum*, nomine missionarii, æque ac postea metropolitæ quosdam ex *Alexandria* in *Indiam* vocatos esse. *Historia Missionis*, P. i. c. 5, p. 30.

² Burton's History of the Christian Church. p. 252.

the Church then emerged from the state of depression into which she had sunk under the severity of the Dioclesian persecution. Constantius Chlorus, who was joint emperor of Rome, at that time commanded the Roman army in Britain, and had his head quarters at York, where he died in the year 306. Before his death, he nominated his son Constantine, afterwards called the Great, as his successor to the imperial throne, and caused the Roman army at York, and even the English there, to proclaim him emperor. But, notwithstanding this precaution, Constantine had to maintain his right with the joint-emperor, Galerius Maximinus, by force of arms. After defeating Galerius in several battles, in the year 308 he forced from him the recognition of his claim. But this did not prevent the two succeeding emperors also, Maxentius and Licinius, from disputing his right. He was equally successful, however, in maintaining it against them both: and after his final triumph over the latter, in the year 323, he became sole emperor of Rome, uniting both the eastern and western empires under his own government. He had hitherto shown a decided predilection for the Gospel of Christ, favouring and protecting the Christians, as their circumstances required, to the extent of his power. But now that he was sole master of his actions, he took the decided step of establishing Christianity as the religion of the state. There is too much reason to believe that his own faith and practice were very defective; but it is not difficult to account for the course he took in favour of a creed which he himself, as it appears, so partially understood. His father, Constantius,¹ had set him

A. D.
306.

Constantine
the Great
establishes
Christianity
as the re-
ligion of the
state.

A. D.
323.

¹ Eusebius' Life of Constantine. Lib. i. ch. 13, 16, and 17.

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the example, and, no doubt, inculcated upon him the duty, of countenancing the Christians. His mother, Helena, is said to have been a Christian,¹ and to have instructed him in the principles of the Gospel from his earliest years. This, however, is uncertain; but there can be little doubt that England was the country of his birth.² The Church of England had long existed under her own hierarchy, independent of the Gallic or Roman, or any other foreign church; and it had flourished for some time under the protection of Constantius.³ It is, therefore, most probable, that Constantine had grown up under the tuition of the British ecclesiastics about his father's court. At the period of his final triumph over Licinius, his mother, Helena, though declining in years, was actuated by no ordinary zeal for the cause of Christ; and as her son paid her the highest respect, and entered with ardour into her suggestions in other matters relating to the church, he was, no doubt, influenced by her counsels to establish Christianity as the religion of the state.⁴ The extraordinary vision also that he had seen in the air some years before, when marching against Maxentius, would combine with the example of

¹ The country and parentage of Helena are involved in uncertainty. It has been affirmed that she was a British princess: but the general opinion is, that she was of low parentage, and a native of Drepane, a city of Bithynia; and that she was one of Constantius' concubines, not receiving the title of Empress until conferred upon her by her son. Eusebius, Jerom, Cassiodorus, and Orosius: all referred to in Du Pin. Fourth century. Constantine, p. 11, note in the margin.

² Stillingfleet. *Origines Britannicæ*. Ch. iii. p. 90.

³ The origin of the British Church will be explained in the sequel.

⁴ Eusebius' *Life of Constantine*, Lib. iii. ch. 42 to 47. See also the notes of Valesius in the margin.

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his father, the lessons of his Christian preceptors, and the advice of his mother, to induce him to act in a manner so becoming a Christian sovereign. He is related to have seen on the occasion referred to, a cross in the air, with this remarkable inscription, *In this conquer*. This occurred at noon-day, and the vision is said to have been represented to him again at night in a dream.¹ Assuming the truth of this relation, that circumstance would naturally induce him to patronise the religion of the cross, and to attribute to its Divine Author all his subsequent triumphs.

Thus Constantine and his mother, whom he had honoured with the title of *Augusta*, and elevated to the imperial dignity, are to be regarded as the first sovereigns in whom, under the Gospel dispensation, was fulfilled the promise to the church of the protection of earthly potentates: "Kings shall be thy nursing fathers, and their queens thy nursing mothers."² It is written in the word of God, "By me Kings reign:"³ and He in justice requires that they reign for Him, as well as by Him. Hitherto Christianity had met with only partial suc-

¹ Eusebius' Life of Constantine, Lib. i. ch. 28—30. Notwithstanding the attempts to throw discredit on this story, (see Maclaine's Mosheim. Cent. 4. p 1. ch. 1. sec. 9. note), I cannot see why it should be deemed incredible. A similar vision appeared to Alexander the Great, when marching with hostile intentions towards Jerusalem, and for a similar purpose—the protection of the Church of God. While we believe that the hearts of kings are in the Almighty's rule and governance, and that He disposes and turns them as seemeth best to His godly wisdom, why is it to be thought undeserving of credit that He should use extraordinary means to control the hearts of these two sovereigns? Josephus' Antiquities, Book ii. ch. 8. sec. 3—5. Rollin also gives the account of Alexander's vision. Ancient History, Vol. v. sec. 7. p. 106, &c.

² Isa. xlix. 23.

³ Prov. viii. 15. Rom. xiii. 1.

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cess in the world, being chiefly confined to towns, whose congregations may be supposed to have been numerous and wealthy enough to maintain their ministers. But there were not sufficient means for the Gospel's pervading the rural districts, where the population was more scattered, and the inhabitants devoid of the advantages essential to the support of its teachers. Accordingly, the villages had almost every where continued to worship the heathen gods, long after the cities had for the most part become Christian. This contrast was so general about that time, that villager and heathen had become synonymous terms, the word *pagan*¹ being applied indifferently to both. But when Constantine established Christianity as the religion of the state, preachers were enabled to go forth into all parts of the Roman empire, to introduce the Gospel where it had not been received, and to minister gratuitously to multitudes who had embraced it, but were unable, through the paucity of their numbers in any one place, to support them in their work.

While, however, under the emperor's auspices, the boundaries of the Church were extended in all directions, it is very doubtful whether the interests of the Christian religion, in its purity and integrity, were promoted in an equal degree. With regard to the church herself, in the ignorance of the Gospel which had long prevailed, and the consequent degeneracy of the Christian character, we cannot be surprised that the godliness which had weathered the storms of persecution, began to decay in the calm of imperial favour.

Mankind cannot bear so sudden a transition

¹ From *pagus*, a village, *paganus*, a villager.

from adversity to prosperity, without the counteracting influence of a much fuller measure of Divine grace than the Christians of that age seem to have possessed. And as to the heathen, the expectation of the emperor's favour proved irresistible, multitudes flocking to the baptismal font, where they were received with little regard to their character, or to their knowledge of the truth. By these means the "cords" of the Christian tabernacle were lengthened, indeed, but "her stakes" not being equally "strengthened"¹ at the same time, she was rendered less able to resist the heresies that soon, as a tempest, burst upon her, and for a long season swept away almost every vestige of truth. In many countries the profession of Christianity was so disguised by superstition and encumbered with secularity, that little more was to be seen of religion than the name.

But all this was accidental, and is to be attributed to the errors of the times, which had been accumulating from the very age of the Apostles. It does not at all affect the abstract question of the emperor's duty to establish Christianity as the religion of his empire, however it may moderate the satisfaction that we cannot but feel on reading of its general acknowledgment and support. Constantine himself understood but little of the religion he professed, having adopted the prevailing heresy of Arius. He remained also in the state of a catechumen all his days, refusing to be baptized till on his death bed, in order that, according to the notions of baptism which then prevailed, his sins might all be washed away when he should have lost the power of contracting fur-

¹ Isa. liv. 2.

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ther guilt. He knew as little also of the duty he owed to those professing a purer faith than his own. Instigated by Eusebius, an Arian Bishop of Nicomedia, towards the close of his reign he persecuted the orthodox, and went so far as to banish several prelates of great eminence. Such intolerance would obscure the setting of even a brighter sun than that of Constantine.

A. D.
325.
Johannes,
Bishop of
Persia and
India, at
the council
of Nice,
A. D. 325.

9. Notwithstanding the assertion of Suidas,¹ that the interior Indians, as well as the Iberians and Armenians, were baptized in the reign of this emperor, it does not appear that the efforts made under his auspices to propagate the Christian religion, produced any immediate effect in India. But two years after the establishment of Christianity as the religion of the empire, we find the next intimation of the existence of that remote Church. At the celebrated Council of Nice, the first Œcumenical Council, which was convened by the emperor's order in the year 325,² one of the prelates assembled, named Johannes, subscribed as Metropolitan of Persia, *and of the Great India.*³ Hence it has been concluded, that the Indian church was at this time in a flourishing condition, and governed by her own prelates. That Bishops did preside over that see is most probable, as, from the age of the Apostles to the present period, and for about twelve hundred years after, no instance occurs of a church established in any part of the world without being governed by its own prelates, as a distinct and superior order to the clergy engaged in the subordinate duties of the mini-

¹ Suidas, in voce 'Αρμένιοι.

² Eusebius, *Life of Constantine*, Lib. iii. c. 6, 7, &c.

³ Act. Synod. Nicæn. Pars Secunda, c. 28. La Croze, p. 44, 'Ιωάννης Πέρσης, τῆς ἐν Περσίῳ πάσης, καὶ τῇ μεγάλῃ Ἰνδίᾳ.

A. D.
323.

sterial office. It can hardly be thought, however, that Johannes was the *resident* Bishop of India. All that may be inferred from his signature is, that his jurisdiction, as Metropolitan of Persia, extended to that vast continent,¹ where the Christians were, probably, at that time, as we know they were subsequently, supplied with Persian ecclesiastics.

10. The political circumstances of Persia at the time when the council of Nice was held, were favourable to this assumption of ecclesiastical authority by the metropolitan of that empire. About a century before, in the reign of Alexander Severus, emperor of Rome, the Persians, at the instigation and under the command of Artaxerxes, revolted against the Parthians, whom they overcame in a hard-fought battle, destroying the greater part of their army, and, after the action, putting their king, Artabanus, to death. The Parthians were now totally subdued, and became in their turn vassals to the Persians, whom they had held in subjection 475 years.

Persia recovers her political independence about this period under Artaxerxes.

Artaxerxes, or Artaxares,² was a Persian of low origin, and of spurious birth, but possessed of consummate abilities, and stimulated by a restless ambition. After his conquest of the Parthians, he mounted the throne of Persia, assumed the pompous title of king of kings, and formed a design of restoring the empire to its ancient glory. Indignant at the thought of any part of the Persian dominions being regarded as a Roman province, he gave notice to the Roman governors of the provinces border-

¹ This may have been similar to the jurisdiction of the Bishop of London in all the colonies of Great Britain, where there are no local B. 78.

² Ardisheer Babigan. Malcom's History of Persia, c. 6.

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II.

ing on his dominions, that he had a just right, as the successor of Cyrus, to all the lesser Asia; which he, therefore, commanded them immediately to evacuate, as well as the provinces on the frontiers of the ancient Parthian kingdom, which he had already reduced to his subjection. The consequence of this haughty message was a war with the emperor of Rome. The opposite parties in this contest each claimed the advantage: and the Roman emperor, Alexander Severus, went so far as to assume the titles of *Parthicus* and *Persicus*. They seem however to have been but empty names, as he does not appear from this period to have held much, if any, dominion in either country: while the Persian king retained full possession of his territories, which, after his decease, were ably defended by his successors against all the endeavours of the Romans to recover them.

Persians
enter with
activity into
the Indian
trade, both
by sea and
land.

11. These events opened to the Persians the direct intercourse with North India by land, and they soon became formidable rivals to the Romans in the commerce with that country by sea. They appear entirely to have surmounted the aversion of their ancestors to maritime pursuits, and to have made early and vigorous efforts in order to acquire a share in the lucrative commerce with India. All its ports of any consideration were frequented by traders from Persia, who bartered some productions of their own country that were in request among the natives of India, for the precious commodities of the East. These they conveyed up the Persian Gulf; and by means of the great rivers, Euphrates and Tigris, they were able to distribute them through every province of the empire. As the voyage from Persia to India was much

shorter than that from Egypt, and attended with less expense and danger, the intercourse between the two countries rapidly increased.¹

12. This brief reference to the history of those times will serve to explain the signature of Johannes at the council of Nice. It will be seen in the sequel, when we shall speak of the first authentic record extant of Christianity in India, that in most of the cities of any note upon the coast of that country,² Christian churches were found at the beginning of the 6th century in a flourishing condition, and that the functions of religion were performed by priests ordained by the Archbishop of Seleucia, the capital of the Persian empire, to whose jurisdiction they continued to be subject. This is in agreement with the popular belief of the present race of Syrian Christians in Travancore. They affirm that the Syriac version of the Scriptures was brought to India before the council of Nice, which was held A. D. 325, and some of their present copies are acknowledged to be of a very ancient date.³

A.D.
325.

Signature of
Johannes at
the council
of Nice ac-
counted for.

¹ Cosmas Indic. Topogr. Christ. Lib. iii. pp. 178, 179. Robertson's India, p. 94.

² Id.

³ Buchanan's Christian Researches, p. 139. The following statement, written in 1814, shows that there is some ground of probability for this belief. "Though written on a strong thick paper, like that of some MSS. in the British Museum, commonly called Eastern paper, the ink has, in several places, eat through the material in the exact form of the letter. In other copies, where the ink had less of a corroding quality, it has fallen off, and left a dark vestige of the letter; faint indeed, but not in general illegible.

"There is a volume, which was deposited in one of the remote churches, near the mountains, which merits a particular description. It contains the Old and New Testaments, engrossed on strong vellum, in large folio, having three columns in a page; and is written with beautiful accuracy.

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On the whole then, this may be considered satisfactory evidence of the existence of this ancient episcopal church at that early period: and here again we cannot but recognise the power and wisdom of the Almighty, in so controlling the violence and ambition of earthly potentates, and the schemes of avaricious and adventurous men, as thereby to subserve His purposes of mercy for the world.¹

Story of
Frumentius
and Œdesius.

13. An ancient author, cited by Suidas, says that the inhabitants of the interior of India were brought over to Christianity during the reign of Constantine the Great; and a story is related by Rufinus,² and repeated by Socrates,³ Sozomen,⁴ Theodoret and others,⁵ which explains the cause of their conversion. A Christian and philosopher, named Meropius, a native of Tyre, reading the account which Metrodorus, another philosopher, had given of his travels in India, felt his curiosity raised to visit that distant region. Accordingly, he sailed to India, in company with two youths who were related to him. The name of the elder was Frumentius, and that of the younger, Œdesius. Having satisfied his curiosity as far as he could, and taken in provisions and water for the voyage home, Meropius prepared to return. The na-

"The character is Estrangelo Syriac, and the words of every book are *numbered*. But the volume has suffered injury from time or neglect. In certain places the ink has been totally obliterated from the page, and left the parchment in its state of natural whiteness: but the letters can in general be distinctly traced from the impress of the pen, or from the partial corrosion of the ink."

¹ La Croze, p. 44.

² Ruf. i. c. 9.

³ Socrates, Lib. i. c. 19—Jortin's Remarks, Vol. iii. p. 126.

⁴ Sozomen, ii. 24.

⁵ Theodoret i. 23—Asseman. Bib. Orient. Tom. i. p. 359. Note 2.

tives, however, for what cause is unknown, put him to death, with all on board his vessel, except his two young kinsmen. These, probably out of compassion for their tender age, they spared, and presented them to their king, who was so much pleased with them that he made the elder, Frumentius, his secretary, and the younger, his cup-bearer. They continued to enjoy the king's confidence and favour until his death, when he bequeathed to them their liberty. The queen, being left in charge of the kingdom during the minority of her son, entreated these strangers to undertake the government of the nation until the prince should come of age. In compliance with her request, they undertook the management of affairs, Frumentius, as before, holding the most responsible office in the state. But, in the constant and arduous occupation of government, he did not forget his obligations, as a Christian ruler, to his God and Saviour. Deeming it a paramount duty to employ the influence of his station for the honour of the Redeemer, and for the encouragement and protection of his fellow-Christians, he diligently inquired of the merchants who traded with that country, whether any Christians resided there. Being answered in the affirmative, he sent for them, made known to them his own creed, and exhorted them to assemble together in separate places of worship, for prayer and mutual edification ; reminding them, at the same time, that such was the general practice of the followers of Jesus. He then erected a small temple, in which they met together for those purposes. Induced by his Christian instructions and example, and, probably, by the countenance he showed them, several of the natives became converts to the Christian profession, and joined in

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the public service of the church. Thus encouraged, their number continued to increase as long as Frumentius remained at the head of affairs : but as soon as the king came of age, he resigned to him the reins of government, and asked permission to return to his native land. He had administered the affairs of the kingdom so much to the satisfaction of the queen and her son, that they were most reluctant to part with him, and earnestly entreated him to remain, but without effect. He quitted India, in company with his brother Œdesius, who hastened to Tyre to visit his parents and kindred : but Frumentius was too intent on succouring the disciples he had left behind, to allow his private affections to interfere with what he regarded as a public duty to the church of Christ.

Arriving at Alexandria, he related the whole story to the Bishop, Athanasius, who had recently been elevated to that see. To this prelate he mentioned the circumstances of his voyage, and explained the grounds of his hope that the Indians generally, under suitable instructions, would embrace the Christian religion. He then urged Athanasius to send a Bishop and a clergyman thither, exhorting him not to neglect those distant sheep who already needed attendance, or others who were yet to be gathered into the fold. The prelate, taking into consideration how this end might best be accomplished, entreated Frumentius to take upon himself the bishopric, declaring that he thought there was no man better qualified than he for the important enterprise. To this proposal Frumentius acceded, and returned to India in the year 356, as Bishop of that country, where he became a zealous and successful preacher of the Gospel, and built many churches

A. D.
356.

A. D.
336.

for the converts made by means of his exertions. Socrates adds, that through Divine grace, he wrought many miracles and cured many men's bodies, together with their souls. That, however, was an age of ignorance and superstition, and therefore one of extreme credulity. Socrates was evidently too fond of the marvellous; and very few, if any, of his relations of this description are worthy of credit.

Rufinus,¹ who gives this interesting narrative, says that he received it from the mouth of Œdesius, the brother of Frumentius. But here also, as in the case of Pantæus, a question has been raised about the country to which Socrates refers, when speaking of the innermost, or most distant India, where the see of this good Bishop was situated. Athanasius, in his Apology to the Emperor Constantine, mentions one Frumentius, Bishop of Auxumis,² which was the capital of Ethiopia: and from this circumstance, Valesius, in his comment upon the History of Socrates,³ has expressed an opinion that Frumentius was Bishop of the country now called Ethiopia, and not of India proper. This interpretation has been followed by Fleury,⁴ Geddes⁵ and other modern writers; but they do not appear to have investigated the grounds of the opinion they adopted.⁶ Baronius, the martyr-ologist,⁷ concluded that there were two Bishops named Frumentius, one presiding over the

¹ Hist. Eccles. Lib. i. c. 9.

² Socrates Scholasticus. Lib. i. c. 19. note (c.)

³ Idem. note (d.) ⁴ Eccl. Hist. Lib. ii. sec. 38.

⁵ History of the Church of Ethiopia, pp. 9, 10.

⁶ The authorities for this conclusion are collected by Fabricius, Lux Evangelii. cap. xxxvi. S. FRUMENTIUS, ET ALII CHRISTIANI IN INDIA, pp. 627, 628. Some of the principal are referred to in the next note.

⁷ Annotations on the Roman Martyrology.

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church of Ethiopia, and the other over that of India proper; the reader will judge whether this is a more reasonable way of solving the difficulty, than by drawing a summary conclusion which would deprive the History of the Indian Church of this interesting narrative. Besides, Bishop Middleton, of Calcutta, spake of Frumentius as "the Apostle of Abyssinia," and said, that "no doubt is entertained, that he became an Indian Bishop." There can be no question that this learned prelate alluded to India proper; for he was addressing a missionary destined for that country,¹ and speaking of it as "certain that the peninsula possessed a knowledge of Christ early in the fourth century"—that is, by means of Frumentius.

It has already been stated, that the innermost India, called also Asian Ethiopia, is described by Socrates as the scene of St. Bartholomew's labours: and although, as we have seen, there is good reason to doubt whether that Apostle ever visited India, yet thus much at least may be gathered from the narrative, that the historian intended particularly to distinguish the two countries from each other; for he speaks of St. Matthew as the Apostle of Ethiopia, properly so called, in immediate connexion with his notice of St. Bartholomew's labours in India.² This at least

¹ The Rev. C. A. Jacobi. Report of the Christian Knowledge Society, 1813, p. 62.

² Lib. i. ch. 19, see sec. 2 of this chapter. Tillemont has truly said, that the name, India, is of a very undetermined signification among the ancients; and he is of opinion, that they applied it to all the countries southward and eastward with which they were unacquainted, and which lay out of the two empires of the Parthians and the Romans. Ecclesiastical Memoirs, tom. i. Sts. Thomas and Bartholomew. In the age of Homer, India was known by the name of Eastern Ethiopia. Part of Africa was called India by the Greeks (Theophylact,

favours the opinion, that Socrates meant to describe this region as the see of Frumentius, rather than Ethiopia. Cosmas also, a writer of the 6th century, who himself visited India, applied to the coast of Malabar the very name here supposed to be mistaken for Ethiopia.¹ Upon the whole then, the probabilities are, to say the least, quite as much in favour of the text of Socrates, as of the comment of Valesius.

It is needless, however, to pursue the inquiry further. But it will not be thought irrelevant thus far, if we consider the important lesson to be learned from the example it brings before us, combined with the probability that it forms a part of the History of Christianity in India. The moral of the story invests it with an interest and importance which otherwise it might hardly, perhaps, be thought to possess. The mere question about its geography is of little moment, compared with the instruction which the narrative conveys. Whatever the country that formed the bishopric of this devoted prelate, his example is worthy of all imitation; and it reminds us of the self-denial of Moses, in the cause of God and his brethren, who, "when he was come to years, refused to be called the son of Pharaoh's daughter; choosing rather to suffer affliction with the people of God, than to enjoy the pleasures of sin for a season, esteeming the

b. iii. c. 9. b. vii. c. 17.) Strabo calls the people of Mauritania, Indians or Hindoos (b. xvii. p. 828); and they are supposed to have been a colony of Indians (Herodotus). In the time of Marco Paolo, Abyssinia was called Middle India. (Asselman, Bib. Orient. tom. i. p. 359, note 1. Asiatic Researches, Vol. iii. pp. 367, 368). And we have just seen (sec. 7 of the present ch.), that the late Dr. Burton supposed that Arabia was called India, in the account of Pantænus.

¹ La Croze, p. 44. &c.

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II.

reproach of Christ greater riches than the treasures of Egypt : for he had respect unto the recompense of reward.”¹ In like manner did this Christian statesman renounce all the power and emoluments of the highest station in the kingdom, and all the honours and pleasures of the court, for the arduous, the humble, the gratuitous work of a missionary to his poor brethren in Christ. In an age of so much ignorance and corruption, when the heresy of Arius was growing rank in the plenitude of imperial favour, and rapidly diffusing its baneful leaven through the church, our spirits find relief in the contemplation of such a picture of Christian fidelity, and we delight to imagine the happiest results from his disinterested exertions. In this application of it, the story appears as a light shining in a dark place ; and it proves that the church was not even then wholly forsaken of her Lord. To those Christians who are reluctant to make any such sacrifices in the Redeemer’s cause, this example speaks in terms of deep reproach : but it addresses the language of encouragement to that disciple who has indeed taken up the cross, and is ready to go forth to proclaim the word of life, wherever duty to his Lord, and the necessities of his fellow-creatures, demand this “ labour of love.”

¹ Heb. xi. 24—26.